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Bank unions defer 3-day strike after talks with IBA

NEWS » PAGE 8



EURASIAN OPPORTUNITIES

Kashmir as India's gateway

Reconnecting the Valley's historic routes could unlock its potential, writes Mehbooba

EDITORIAL » PAGE 6



CHESS OLYMPIAD

Indian men win silver, women claim bronze

SPORT » PAGE 14



EC steps won't undo 'mass disenfranchisement': Cong.

Poll panel's proposed measures amount to an admission that the SIR exercise has been a 'disaster', says Congress leader; targeted removal of marginalised voters meant to benefit the BJP, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after the Election Commission announced multiple steps to address concerns about the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress on Sunday termed them a "desperate attempt at damage control" that "hides all and reveals nothing".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the proposed measures amounted to an admission that the exercise had been a "disaster", warning that the "piecemeal" steps would do little to mitigate what he called "mass disenfranchisement".

He questioned several of the assurances given by



Congress workers take out a demonstration in Kolkata on Saturday demanding the suspension of the SIR. AP

the EC, including its proposal to review the ECINet software and plan for booth-level officers to visit the electors who received notices. "We know that in practice these visits were sparse and sporadic. What is the value of promising a second round of visits which likely will not hap-

pen? The logic of repeating a process done poorly once must be examined," he said.

Questioning the rationale of the entire SIR process, which he described as a "colossal waste" of resources, Mr. Ramesh said that nearly 14 crore voters whose names were deleted

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI against EC

NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, urging him to initiate *suo motu* proceedings against the conduct of the Election Commission regarding the SIR and the deployment of the ECINet software. » PAGE 9

from the rolls were now being asked to apply afresh for inclusion. The targeted removal of marginalised voters was meant to benefit the BJP, he said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8
EDITORIAL
» PAGE 6

GBA draft Parking Rules draw over 800 objections

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

More than 800 objections have been made to the Greater Bengaluru Authority's (GBA) draft Parking Rules, prompting the government to refer the policy to a legal research firm for a review from an academic perspective, according to government sources.

M. Maheshwar Rao, Chief Commissioner, GBA, said that the policy would undergo further scrutiny, with objections and suggestions also being forwarded to the firm. He added that the draft had received a positive response from citizens as well.

Major objections
Government sources said that the major objections pertain to paid parking and parking permit charg-



Parked vehicles at Koramangala. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

es. Soon after the draft policy was published, Forest Minister Ramalinga Reddy had also written to Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar seeking a comprehensive review of the proposed parking permit charges, which range from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 annually.

RELATED REPORT ON
» PAGE 2

NEARBY



Oppn. refuses to be part of delegation

BENGALURU

The BJP and the JD(S) have refused to be part of the all-party delegation planned by the Karnataka government to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek Central assistance for drought relief. » PAGE 4

'Drugs being sold at up to 70 times buying cost'

BENGALURU

Pointing out that high-cost medicines are being sold at prices up to "70 times higher" than their buying cost, Health Minister U.T. Khader has sought action against "abnormal gaps" in drug prices. » PAGE 5

Cabinet vacancies will be discussed in Delhi: DKS

BENGALURU

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday said that discussions regarding filling the remaining two Cabinet berths would be held during his visit to Delhi. » PAGE 4

KEA plans three-layered OMR sheets

BENGALURU

The Karnataka Examinations Authority is considering the introduction of three-layered OMR sheets to effectively prevent malpractices during various recruitment examinations. » PAGE 3

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5

5 'terrorists' held near U.K. base used by U.S.

Agence France-Presse
FAIRFORD

British counter-terrorism forces were probing "a major incident" near a base used by the U.S. Air Force in its war against Iran after arresting five men on suspicion of "preparing a terrorist act", the police said on Sunday.

Armed officers detained the group in the early hours after a call to emergency services about three "suspicious vehicles which appeared to be travelling towards the air base", London's Metropolitan Police said in a statement.

U.S. President Donald Trump said that the suspects were aiming at doing significant damage to the



A U.S. B-1B Lancer bomber on the tarmac of the Fairford air base on Sunday. REUTERS

base. "We had them under investigation... they were looking to do big damage to our fort, and working with the British worked out great," he told presspersons. "We had them under view for a long time, and we got them," he added.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Joy unbound



Silver lining: Ancy Sojan is over the moon after winning the silver medal in the women's long jump at the Asian Games on Sunday. Sarvesh Kushare (high jump), Anahat Singh, and Abhay Singh (squash) too won silver medals on Sunday. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 13)

25 km in raging river amid crocodiles, the longest night for 75-year-old Odisha woman

Septuagenarian from Jajpur survives 12 hours in the swollen Brahmani river after falling into it at night; she braves strong floodwaters before being rescued from a neighbouring district on Sunday

Satvasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For more than 12 hours in pitch darkness, Keshi Dalai, 75, clung to life as the raging Brahmani river in Odisha carried her through swollen floodwaters for nearly 25 km.

With crocodiles lurking in the turbulent waters and the river showing no mercy, every passing minute brought her closer to death. Yet, against all odds, the septuagenarian survived the ordeal and was rescued alive on



Keshi Dalai after her rescue in Kendrapara of Odisha on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sunday morning. Ms. Dalai, a resident of Kalakhanda, a riverside village in Jajpur district, had gone to the riverbank to relieve herself late on Saturday evening while her family was asleep. She

was swept away by the Brahmani river, which was in spate following heavy rain, after she lost her balance.

The stretch of the Brahmani where she fell in is known for its crocodiles. Residents have erected barricades in the water at several places for protection. More than 20 people have been dragged into the river by crocodiles over the past five years. Against this backdrop, Ms. Dalai's survival through the dead of night is being hailed as nothing short of a miracle.

Throughout the night,

Ms. Dalai managed to remain afloat. On Sunday morning, she was spotted waving for help and was rescued by a group of youth at Balipatna village in Kendrapara district – at a distance of 25 km by river course and 45 km by road from her village. "In the morning, we could not find her. As the search continued, a call from the Pattamundai police in Kendrapara brought us immense relief," said Aranya Dalai, Ms. Dalai's son-in-law.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Student protests erupt over Punjab 'campus rape' in LPU

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Allegations that a student was raped on the campus of Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab sparked an agitation that led to protesters, mainly students, blocking National Highway-44 near Phagwara on Sunday.

The stir, which took place hours after the protesters went on a rampage and vandalised university property, disrupted traffic and led to clashes with the police.

FIR registered

The police registered a first information report (FIR) containing rape charges against unknown persons and a special investigation



Protesters block the National Highway near LPU campus in Punjab on Sunday. PTI

team has been constituted to probe the matter.

The students have alleged that a female hosteller had been raped by a plumber three days ago and claimed that no action

had been taken in the matter so far. LPU, a private institute, has denied the allegations.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Over 800 objections prompt fresh review of Parking Rules

Civic groups say that the policy is more focused on revenue generation and is upper-middle-class-orientated, rather than striking balance between traffic management and maintaining discipline

Chetan B.C.
BENGALURU

Over 800 objections have been received against the Greater Bengaluru Authority's (GBA) draft Parking Rules, prompting the government to send the policy to a legal research firm for a review from an academic perspective, according to government sources.

M. Maheshwar Rao, Chief Commissioner, GBA, said that the policy would be scrutinised again, with the objections and suggestions also being sent to the firm. He stressed that the policy has also received a positive response from citizens. Other government sources revealed that the major objections are related to paid parking and parking permit charges. When the draft policy was



Other government sources revealed that the major objections are related to paid parking and parking permit charges. SUDHAKARA JAIN

published, even Forest Minister Ramalinga Reddy wrote to the Chief Minister seeking a comprehensive review of the proposed parking permit charges, which now range from an annual cost of ₹15,000 to ₹25,000.

Meanwhile, civic groups pointed out that the policy is more focused on revenue generation and is upper-middle-class-orientat-

ed, rather than striking a balance between traffic management, maintaining parking discipline and generating revenue. They, however, support several rules, such as expanding parking infrastructure and imposing restrictions.

Changes expected
Sajjan Raj Mehta, trade activist, who has also submitted objections, said that

Concerns and solutions

Objection	Changes sought
Paid parking charges on arterial roads (Two-wheelers: ₹20/hour, cars: ₹40/hour)	Exempt two-wheelers from charges based on road categories
Annual parking permit fee	Introduce slabs and reduce charges
Parking operators holding enforcement powers	Clearly establish rules for private players
Complete implementation of policy	Phased implementation after reviewing available public transport options
Policy perceived as a revenue-generating avenue	Reduce charges wherever possible and ring-fence the revenue

the Urban Development Department should constitute a Parking Advisory Committee comprising civic groups, resident welfare associations and trade associations, as including these stakeholders would make the policy scientific.

“The government's primary objective should be mobility management and public welfare, not merely the monetisation of

every available portion of public road space. He stated that the parking policy should aim to reduce congestion, improve pedestrian safety, and encourage public transport, rather than simply enforcing fees,” he said.

Dattatraya Devare, a civic activist who welcomed the policy, said that such rules are long-delayed, while also stressing that



The Urban Development Department should constitute a Parking Advisory Committee comprising civic groups, resident welfare associations and trade associations

SAJJAN RAJ MEHTA
Trade activist

there may be a need to review the pricing.

“While the policy was needed, it doesn't consider all sections of society, which include families who dream of owning a single car or even cab drivers. So, the government may consider introducing slabs with a lesser annual fee for single-car owners and a higher price for multiple-car owners,” he said.

The Forest Minister's letter highlighted this loophole, as it stressed that many middle-class residents in older layouts and smaller houses lacked internal parking facilities and that the policy would cause burden on them.

Another major issue flagged by the groups is the entire management of residential parking being given to private players, which could create scope for citizen harassment without stricter management rules being imposed on them.

Implementation issues

On the contrary, N.S. Mukunda of Bengaluru Praja Vedic explained that many residents would readily take the parking permits while also acknowledging that they are not attractive to all sections of society. “The policy offers a car

owner official permission for a space for parking, which would eliminate the small fights that occur in a neighbourhood over parking space. So, people would readily avoid such fights through having an official space,” he explained.

However, he pointed out that the implementation would reduce road space by one-third, creating congestion points, especially in smaller neighbourhoods. He also stated that changes were required to make the policy not a mere revenue-generating avenue but address the traffic management issue.

Amid these problematic rules, the policy imposes restrictions on parking at bus bays, shifting of autorickshaw stands, creation of off-street parking and digital data on parking spots in the city, among others.

Symbol of protest



Temperature rising: Activists staging a symbolic funeral for the Election Commission near the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer, to protest on issues related to the SIR on Sunday. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

People booked for unauthorised protest in Bidadi

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Bidadi police have registered an FIR against a group of protesters for allegedly staging an unauthorised demonstration at Bairamangala against the Bidadi Township project and disrupting traffic and normal public life.

Based on a complaint filed by Devaraj, PSI, the police have booked the protesters under Sections 126(2), (wrongful restraint) 54 (abatement) and 190 (unlawful assembly) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and initiated an investigation.

According to the complaint, the accused, including Girish, Chetan, Chandrashekar, Shivrudrappa, Veeresh, Puttaswamy, Bhairappa, Krishnappa, Nagaraju, Jayamma, Jayalakshmi, Shwetha, Bhagya and Netha, along with others, allegedly staged an unauthorised protest at Bairamangal Circle.

The protesters allegedly placed chairs on the road, sat and lay down on the carriageway, and parked tractors and bullock carts across the road. They also allegedly tied cattle on the road, obstructing the movement of vehicles.

The protest reportedly began around 10 a.m. on September 21 and continued on September 22, 23, 24 and 25.

The Bidadi-Harohalli road is part of State Highway 265 and passes through an industrial area. Police said the road blockade caused inconvenience

to the public, schoolchildren, employees and goods transport vehicles.

The protesters also allegedly encouraged other women and members of the public to join the agitation. The protesters gathered along the road leading towards Bairamangala and raised various demands concerning the Bidadi Township project.

The police report names several individuals in connection with the alleged unauthorised protest and related activities. Police said further investigation was under way to establish the role of those named in the complaint and determine the circumstances surrounding the alleged disruption. Police officials said appropriate legal action would be taken based on the investigation.

DKS reacts

Reacting to the road blocking incident, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said, “Blocking a road causes inconvenience to the public. We are not putting pressure on anyone to give their land. Those who need money to build their lives will give their land, while those who do not want to give it need not.”

On the other hand, Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy questioned why the police intervened after five days of protest.

“The farmers had been observing a hunger strike at the same place for five days and no action was taken. Why did they intervene on the fifth day,” he questioned.

HDK to meet affected families during tour along NICE stretch

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy on Sunday announced that he will visit villages along the Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprises (NICE) Road and meet all the families affected by the project from October 2.

Mr. Kumaraswamy interacted with farmers who lost their land for the NICE project and received their representations. He promised the farmers that he would fight against the project.

Addressing the media after the interaction, Mr. Kumaraswamy said the court had observed that the NICE Road toll was be-



H.D. Kumaraswamy during the interaction with farmers on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

out at the government, Mr. Kumaraswamy alleged that they were protecting promoter of NICE Road, Ashok Kheny, despite the High Court having made strong observations, and questioned their continued support. The union minister said he would visit all the villages from Madavara to Electronics City along the NICE stretch and speak to the affected families.

“If the government's stand remains the same even after I complete visiting the villages, I will decide my next step to protest the issue,” he said.

He also said he would make a detailed presentation on what had happened in the past with regard to the project.

Court extends ED custody of IAS officer by eight days

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A Bengaluru court on Saturday extended the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) custody of IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar by another eight days in connection with its probe into alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) recruitment process.

Gangwar, who was arrested by the ED a week ago, had initially been remanded in six days of agency custody. He was produced before the court on Saturday and ED sought an extension, submitting that its investigation had uncovered information beyond the findings of the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) in the alleged irregularities in the

Veterinary Officers' Recruitment Examination.

The agency also reportedly submitted its findings to the court in a sealed cover. The ED informed the court that it suspected irregularities in multiple recruitment examinations and sought further custody to investigate the alleged money trail and other aspects of the case.

During an earlier custody hearing, the ED had alleged that Basavaraj Kanne, described by the agency as another key suspect and an associate of Gangwar, told investigators that several candidates had allegedly paid amounts of up to ₹1.5 crore. The ED further alleged that Kanne handed over ₹1.3 crore in cash to Gangwar.

Based on these allegations, the ED has initiated a

money-laundering investigation under Sections 3 and 4 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

The ED has also alleged that Gangwar provided Kannale with question papers and answers on an HP pendrive on January 7, two days before the scheduled examination. A separate CID investigation had earlier reportedly found that around 60 to 80 questions were leaked to candidates and that around five candidates were allegedly given practice in answering the questions.

The allegations are part of an ongoing investigation, and the court's decision to extend custody does not by itself establish guilt. Further investigation by the ED and CID is continuing.

‘Karnataka Mantapa’ in the offing?

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

“The government is considering constructing a ‘Karnataka Mantapa’—modelled after Delhi's ‘Bharat Mandapam’—at locations such as Jakkur, Mysore Lamps, or NGEF,” Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said. He was speaking after inaugurating the first-ever Karnataka Tourism Awards ceremony, held at Palace Grounds to mark World Tourism Day. It was organised by the Department of Tourism and Karnataka Tourism Society.

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TRAFFIC DEPARTMENT
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NO. C6/457/2026/T dt.28.09.2026

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For further details visit Ch.P.A. website www.chennaiport.gov.in and www.eprocure.gov.in

TRAFFIC MANAGER

KARNATAKA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

(CIN: U40109KA1999SGC025521)
No. CEE/Tr(OP)/ZM/SEE(O)/AEE-3/2026-27/5447-49 Date: 25.09.2026

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E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with provision to rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the symbolic possession of which has been taken by the Authorised officer of Union Bank of India (secured Creditor) will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is basis" on the date mentioned below, for recovery of dues as mentioned hereunder to Union bank of India from the below mentioned Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and the Earnest Money Deposit are also mentioned hereunder.

Harohalli Branch, Kempaiah Building, Harohalli Village & Post, Ramanagara - 562112
Ph: 7351002858, Mail Id: ubin0814580@unionbankofindia.bank.in

1. Name And Address Of the Borrower, Co-application And Guarantor :
1) Mr. Srikanthiah G C, S/o Late Chame Gowda, Gottigehalli Village, Harohalli Hobli, Kanakapura Taluk, Ramanagara - 562117
2. Mr. Shivanna T S/o Thimmegowda (as He Is Deceased) His Legal Heirs
2 (a) Chaluvaramma W/o Late Shivanna T.
2. (b) Mr. Madhu Gowda S/o Late Shivanna T.
2.(c) Ms Nethravathi D/o Late Shivanna T.
2.(d) Ms Nirguna D/o Late Shivanna T.
All are residing At Gottigehalli Village, Harohalli Hobli, Kanakapura Taluk, Ramanagara - 562112
Amount due : Rs. 2,20,788-00 as on 31-08-2026 with further interest, cost & expenses
Description of immovable secured assets to be Sold : All The Part And The Parcel Of Residential House In The Name Of **Mr. Srikanthiah**, Bearing Property No. 24/87/A, Khaneshumari No. 19/87, Gottigehalli Village, Harohalli Hobli, Kanakapura Taluk, Ramanagara Dist. **Measuring East - West : 43 feet, North - South : 45 feet, Total 1935 square feet, Bounded On The East: Property Of Bachchegowda, West: Shankarappa G N Shivanna's Property, North: Property Of Smt Chikkananjamma And Road, South: Property Of Smt. Thyai Muddamma.**

Reserve Price : Rs. 23,81,734-00
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Earnest Money to Be Deposited :
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2. Name And Address Of the Borrower, Co-application And Guarantor :
1. Mr. Swamy M (as he is Deceased, His Legal Heirs) A. Mrs. Manjula M W/o Late Swamy M, B. Master Yogaraju S C., Miss Amrutha S, All are Residing at : Karadi Gudde Pipeline Road, SAMRAT Ashoka Nagara, Kanakapura Town, Ramanagara - 562117
2. Mrs. Manjula M W/o Late Swamy M, Karadi Gudde Pipeline Road, SAMRAT Ashoka Nagara, Kanakapura Town, Ramanagara - 562117
Amount due : Rs. 19,24,223-00 as on 31-08-2026 with further interest, cost & expenses
Description of immovable secured assets to be Sold : All The Part And The Parcel Of Residential House In The Name Of **Mr. Late. Swamy M.** Bearing No 77, CMC Khattha No 9020/7710/77, Situated At Eastern Side Of Mysuru Road, Pipe Line Road, Kanakapura, Ramanagara - 562117, **Measuring East-West 40 Feet, North-South 20 Feet, Total 800 Sqare feet, Bounded By East- Site No 76, West-Road, North- Site No 78, South-Road.**

Reserve Price : Rs. 29,35,319-00
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Last date for submission of EMD : On or before the commencement of e-Auction.
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For detailed terms and conditions of the sale and registration and login and bidding rules visit : please refer to the link provided : <https://www.unionbankofindia.co.in/auction-property/view-auction-property.aspx> and www.unionbankofindia.co.in

Date : 28-09-2026
Place : Mysuru

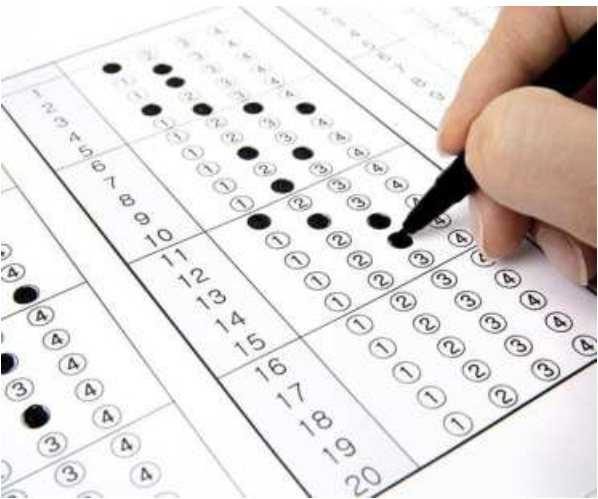
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KEA plans three-layered OMR sheets to prevent malpractices

The move comes following allegations of tampering of OMR sheets that featured prominently in various recruitment exams

Jayanth R.
BENGALURU

The Karnataka Examinations Authority (KEA) is considering the introduction of three-layered Optical Mark Recognition (OMR) sheets to effectively prevent malpractices during various recruitment examinations. As per the proposal, the original sheet is to be submitted to the KEA after the exam concludes. Second copy will be the student copy and is handed over to the candidates. The third copy is to be stored in the strong rooms at the offices of the Deputy Commissioners (DCs) in the respective districts. The KEA successfully implemented three-layered OMR sheets on a trial basis during the recent Police Constable



Experiment: The KEA successfully implemented three-layered OMR sheets on a trial basis during the recent Police Constable (KSRP) recruitment examination.

(KSRP) recruitment examination. Consequently, it is now considering adopting the same system for future recruitment exams. The examination system in Karnataka has been

mired in controversy. The Karnataka High Court has initiated an investigation by constituting a Special Investigation Team (SIT) regarding various recruit- ment irregularities at the

Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC). Additionally, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Criminal Investigation Department (CID) have conducted investigations into the matter. Allegations regarding the tampering of OMR sheets have featured prominently in the various recruitment examinations. It has been alleged that some candidates left the circles on their OMR sheets blank, and they were filled later through illicit means to secure high marks and obtain the posts.

Current system Currently, recruitment authorities in the State, such as the KPSC and KEA, use double-layered OMR sheets. In this system, the original copy is submitted to the KEA or KPSC, while the other copy is given to

the candidates. Speaking to *The Hindu*, H. Prasanna, Executive Director of KEA and the Controller of Examinations for KPSC, said, “There were allegations regarding the tampering of OMR sheets at the KPSC. Consequently, we are considering the introduction of triple-layered OMR sheets.” “This third OMR copy will be kept safe at the DC’s office until the entire recruitment process – including the resolution of any court dispute – is concluded and appointment orders are issued to the candidates. Should allegations of OMR tampering arise, this system will facilitate a comparison and verification of all three copies. Subsequently, they will be disposed of in accordance with the rules,” Mr. Prasanna said.

Baby’s day out



Ready, set, go: A man carrying his child during the 13th edition of the Wipro Bengaluru Marathon near Vidhana Soudha on Sunday. Over 45,000 runners participated in the event, organised by NEB Sports, in association with the Karnataka Athletics Association, Wipro Bangalore and Shriram Properties. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Four lion cubs die within a day of birth

The Hindu Bureau
SHIVAMOGGA

Sara, a three-year-old lioness at the Shivamogga Zoo, gave birth to four cubs – two male and two female – a few days ago, but all four died within a day, dealing a setback to the zoo’s lion breeding programme. Sara, brought to the zoo from Indore in September 2025, had been paired with Shiva, a male lion. Animal keepers had noticed the pair mating three months ago. However, there were hardly any signs of pregnancy, and she mated with the male again – unusual during pregnancy – leading the staff to conclude that she was not pregnant. Officials said they were not anticipating the delivery of cubs. However, Sara gave birth at night in the second week of September. Keepers noticed she was not nursing the cubs, and they began showing signs of dehydration. Officials said her handling of the cubs was abnormal – attributed to it being her first pregnancy – which, combined with the lack of feeding, left the cubs at serious risk.

☀️🌧️ Timings
BENGALURU

MONDAY, SEP. 28

☀️ RISE 06:09 SET 18:12

🌧️ RISE 19:20 SET 07:21

TUESDAY, SEP. 29

☀️ RISE 06:09 SET 18:11

🌧️ RISE 20:07 SET 08:17

WEDNESDAY, SEP. 30

☀️ RISE 06:09 SET 18:10

🌧️ RISE 21:00 SET 09:18

Bengaluru Weather	max	min
Tumakuru	34	15
Mysuru	29	18
Bengaluru	30	20

Bengaluru Today
30°C The weather will be dry. Day will be slight warm. Night will be pleasant.

Bengaluru Tomorrow
29°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be slight warm. Night also will be pleasant. Spell of rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.

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THE HINDU
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Over 84,000 hectares of coconut plantations damaged in State

DROUGHT
Rashmi Patil
BENGALURU

Karnataka’s severe drought has damaged 84,656 hectares of coconut plantations across the State, with officials warning that the impact on the crop could persist for up to three years due to the long growth cycle of coconut trees. According to the officials of the Department of Horticulture, among all horticultural crops that have surveyed in past months, coconut has recorded the highest crop loss, followed by onion and other vegetables. They said that the impact of this drought would remain for the next three years. A senior official who spoke to *The Hindu* said, “As per the instructions of the government, survey was conducted jointly by the departments, including horticulture, revenue, Karnataka State Natural Disaster Management



Withered: Coconut has recorded the highest crop loss, followed by onion and other vegetables. FILE PHOTO

Authority and others, in 124 taluks that are listed in the severely drought-affected category. It recorded that ₹59,259 lakh worth coconut crop cultivated on 84,656 hectares out of 5.6 lakh hectares has been impacted. Recently, more than 50 taluks were added to the list, and we will study the crop loss of coconut in the remaining taluks in districts including Tumakuru, Chitradurga in the next 15 days.” **Hassan worst affected** The official said, “For now, Haasan district is the worst affected as it is the hub of

Officials warn that the impact of the drought on the coconut crop can persist for up to three years

coconut cultivation after Tumakuru, Mandya, Chitradurga, coastal Karnataka and some parts of Malnad region. Around 84,541 hectares of crop loss out of 97,999 has been recorded in Haasan, along with 115 hectares, in Haveri.” While stressing the pending survey in newly added taluks, the official said, “The crop loss is like-

At a glance	
District	Crop loss (in hectares)
Hassan	84,541
Haveri	115
Mandya	0
Chitradurga	0
Total	84,656
Crop loss estimation (in ₹)	59,259 lakh
Source: Department of Horticulture	
Cultivation area in four major districts	
District	Coconut plantation (in hectares)
Tumakuru	1,78,748
Hassan	97,999
Mandya	67,106
Chitradurga	38,30
Source: Coconut Development Board	

ly to increase once the drought survey is completed. The total value of crop and the assistance for farmers that will be sought from the government can be assessed after the completion of the survey.” Shakil Ahmed, Joint Director, Horticulture Department, explained, “Extreme heat and water

scarcity affect the flowering and fruiting processes of coconut trees. Whether the drought lasts one year or longer, its impact on the crop is long-term, as the dry spell disrupts the tree’s development cycle, including flowering and fruiting, which can span up to 36 months.” It also damages the roots, which fail to absorb water and nutrients from the soil and manure, resulting in a multi-year lag, he said. Mr. Ahmed said that the impact will be on farmers, farm labourers seeking jobs, price fluctuations and a large economic impact on the State’s finances. “Karnataka, which has around 5.6 lakh hectares under coconut cultivation, is second only to Kerala’s 7 lakh hectares. Unlike Kerala and Tamil Nadu, much of Karnataka’s coconut is grown in dry zones. Farmers rely on drip irrigation, but many water sources and borewells have gone dry this year,” the Joint Director said. Meanwhile, K. Narayan Gowda, former

Vice-Chancellor of the University of Agricultural Sciences, Bengaluru, studied coconut plantations in taluks across Mandya, Tumakuru and other districts. “Drought is worsening pests such as black-headed caterpillar, Rugose Spiralling Whitefly and Kappu Masi disease. I have submitted recommendations to the government to help farmers control them. Compensation alone will not save thousands of coconut trees,” Mr. Gowda said. Mari Gowda, a coconut growing farmer from Haasan district, said, “This year, the crop yield will reduce owing to extreme heat and withering of flowers. For instance, if there are 50 trees in one acre, earlier the yield was 90 to 100 coconuts. Now, it has reduced 30 to 50. In 2023, there was drought and the same impact was felt. I was happy this year because I thought I would receive a good yield after three years, but drought has once again caused misery.”

St. Joseph’s University organises third annual convocation

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

St. Joseph’s University organised third annual convocation on Sunday in Bengaluru. Around 2,300 graduates were awarded with degree in various disciplines. A total of 123 UG and PG students received silver and gold medals for their academic achievements. On the occasion, Home Minister Priyank Kharge said, “Students should be curious, learn from failures and keep trying.” Prem Watsa, founder, chairman and CEO of Fairfax Financial Holdings Limited, Canada, announced support of around \$5 million. Mr. Watsa highlighted India’s rapid economic growth and wide variety of opportunities available to students after college.

MARUTI SUZUKI

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Oppn. refuses to be part of all-party delegation to Centre over drought relief

The Chief Minister, at the end of a four-day special session, announced that an all-party delegation will be taken to the Pime Minister to seek assistance in drought mitigation efforts

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Janata Dal (Secular) (JD(S)) have refused to be part of the proposed all-party delegation planned by the Karnataka government to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek Central assistance for drought relief.

On Sunday, Union Minister and JD(S) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy and Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Assembly R. Ashok said that they would not be part of the proposed delegation.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar is leaving for Delhi on Monday to take part in the Congress Working Committee meeting scheduled for Tuesday. The Chief Minister had earlier indicated that the government is seeking a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and an all-party delegation from Karnataka.

Mr. Kumaraswamy said that the State representatives could go on their own, and that there was no need for an all-party delegation.

The Chief Minister, at the end of the four-day special session convened to



The Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Assembly has accused the Congress government of lacking commitment to help drought-hit farmers in Karnataka. FILE PHOTO

discuss the drought, farmers' distress, and the Kasturangan Committee report, announced that an all-party delegation would be taken to the Prime Minister to seek Central assistance in drought mitigation efforts.

"What will you do by taking an all-party delegation to the Centre? It will add to the expenditure of the exchequer. Spending on flights and stay in star-category hotels is an unnecessary expenditure. Could someone not go and speak to the Centre?" the Union Minister told press-

persons here on Sunday.

Stating that he would not say that the State has gone bankrupt, he said: "It is you who has been sitting on an empty treasury."

Meanwhile, Mr. Ashok said that they would not go to the Centre to seek funds for drought relief. "We are ready to meet the Union Minister with respect to the Kasturirangan report. We will not be part of the drought delegation," he said. He accused the Congress government of lacking commitment to help the drought-hit farmers in Karnataka.

Central team to arrive for drought assessment

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

After the State's first memorandum to the Centre regarding the drought situation, estimating a loss of around ₹18,000 crores and seeking about ₹3,800 crores as assistance from the Centre, a team from the Union government will arrive in Karnataka for a drought assessment on October 3. The team will be visiting the drought-affected areas for three days from October 4 and will be holding discussions with Chief Secretary Shalini Rajneesh on October 7.

Three Inter Ministerial Central Teams will assess crop damage and geographic conditions. While one team will assess Tumakuru, Chitradurga, Davanagere and Vijayanagara districts, the second team will visit Hassan, Mysuru and Chamarajanagar (it may include Mandya). The third team will visit Yadgir, Bagalkote, Raichur and Koppal districts.

Decision on ministerial representation for women to be discussed in Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday said that discussions regarding filling the remaining two Cabinet berths would be held during his visit to Delhi. "The issue of accommodating a woman in the Cabinet will be discussed in Delhi," he told presspersons here.

The Chief Minister is headed to Delhi to take part in the Congress Working Committee meeting scheduled for Tuesday to discuss the issue of the



D.K. Shivakumar

Election Commission of India and the ongoing Special Intensive Revision

exercise across the country.

A meeting of Opposition leaders has also been convened to discuss the same, Mr. Shivakumar said.

Consensus
Sources said party leaders in the State have not yet arrived at a consensus on who the woman legislator to be taken into the Cabinet will be, though some names are doing the rounds.

"Unless leaders come to a consensus, the Cabinet expansion would not be

possible," sources said.

When asked about the appointment of chairpersons to boards and corporations, he said a decision had already been taken in Delhi. "Senior legislators would be accommodated, and party workers would be appointed later," he said.

Incidentally, Congress General Secretary in charge of Karnataka Randeep Singh Surjewala held discussions with the Chief Minister and prospective legislators last week before finalising the names.

Ashok challenges Congress to face fresh polls in States where they are in power

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Accusing the Congress of following double standards in questioning the election process, including EVMs whenever it loses, Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Assembly R. Ashok on Sunday challenged the Congress to cancel the election to State Assemblies where it has won, including Karnataka, and face fresh polls.

Addressing a press conference in Bengaluru, Mr. Ashok alleged that the Congress was disillusioned that it would not win the Parliamentary polls again. "That is why Rahul Gandhi speaks against Constitutional institutions such as

the Supreme Court, the Directorate of Enforcement and the Central Bureau of Investigation. Now, for political gains, Congress leaders are targeting the Election Commission," he said.

"Uttar Pradesh elections are due in February, and it is certain that the Congress will not win even one seat there. Akhilesh Yadav has declined to tie up with them. That is why they are attacking the Election Commission now itself. It is like seeking anticipatory bail," he said.

SIR
"If there is an error in the Special Intensive Revision, they should file a case in the Supreme Court, but they are not going to court



Leader of Opposition R. Ashok during a press meet at the BJP State office in Bengaluru on Sunday. SUDHAKARA JAIN

because there is no document to prove that there is a flaw. During the time of Nehru and Indira Gandhi,

Ashok alleges that the Congress is disillusioned that it will not win the Parliamentary polls again

people who worked in their homes and their relatives were appointed as Election Commissioners," he said.

He took exception to Congress leaders opposing the court's direction to appoint a Special Investigation Team to look into irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission and termed this as the extent to which Congress leaders would go to oppose reforms for political gains.

Uttaradi seer survives accident

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI

Uttaradi mutt seer Satyatma Teertha Swami was discharged from a private hospital in Hubballi on Sunday evening after briefly undergoing treatment following a road accident on Saturday night. Two others, in-

cluding Shashidharacharya, were injured. All are out of danger.

In a video message for mutt devotees, he said that he had not suffered any major injury. "There is no need for panic or worry. I was saved by the blessings of my gurus and Almighty God," he said. The mutt

clarified on Sunday morning that he was out of danger. The Sushruta Multiplicity Hospital released a statement saying he had undergone all relevant tests and the results were normal.

An SUV carrying the seer had met with an accident on NH-48, recently.

It is ironic that Veerashaiava-Lingayat community has to seek justice: Khandre

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Minister Eshwar Khandre on Sunday said that it was ironic that a community that worked for social justice in society is seeking justice now.

"There are poor families in the community like in other communities. They too should get justice. The Sharanas worked for



Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar inaugurating the Veerashaiva-Lingayat Dharma Samrakshana convention in Bengaluru on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Khandre says that the Anubhava Mantapa will be ready by the end of next year

Veerashaiva-Lingayat Dharma Samrakshana convention here.

He, however, said that it is unfortunate that in the current times the community has to seek justice. "Some are sowing seeds of hatred between communi-

ties for their selfish gains," he said, terming Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, who was also present, of having a secular mindset.

On the occasion, Mr. Khandre also said that the Anubhava Mantapa coming up at a cost of ₹750 crore in Basavakalyan will be ready by the end of next year.

A number of Veerashaiva-Lingayat mutt seers and political leaders from the community were present.

CORRIDORS OF POWER

'Give us your washing machine'
Discussions over drought in the recently concluded special session of the Karnataka legislature often veered towards other political issues, leading to confrontations. One such incident occurred when a Congress member in the Legislative Council, S. Ravi, invoked the "washing machine" metaphor to attack the BJP. Mr. Ravi said the BJP possessed a "washing machine" that could turn politicians facing allegations squeaky clean if they moved to the saffron party's side. He referred to political leaders facing action by agencies such as the Income Tax Department, the Directorate of Enforcement, and the CBI, and alleged that leaders were treated differently after joining or aligning with the BJP. "In the future, when we form the government at the Centre, you must lend us that technology. We will also give you a good wash," he said. Mr. Ravi also cautioned against assuming that the present political situation was permanent. The remarks triggered laughter from the treasury benches and interruptions from Opposition members,

leading to a brief verbal exchange.

Singer for all occasions
JD(S) member in the Legislative Council S.L. Bhoje Gowda's (pictured) penchant for singing is well known, often turning the House into a concert hall. Even amid serious discussions on agrarian distress in the recent session, he broke into a song from his childhood on the same theme. This time, he had P.V. Mohan, a Congress member, also join him in the singing. In the past too, Mr. Gowda has spared no opportunity to sing. In August, he broke into song to congratulate veteran actor-turned-politician Umashree after she was elected the Deputy Chairperson of the Council. Similarly, last year, he sang to congratulate Basavaraj Horatti for his unbeaten 45-year run as MLC. Mr. Gowda sang a song from the Kannada movie *Besuge* and described the Chairman as a guiding force for legislators over several decades. On another occasion, when members were discussing



the problems faced by adolescents, with special reference to female adolescents, the MLC broke into a Kannada song by Gururaj Hoskote, describing the pain of a mother while marrying off her daughter.

No respite from apps
Government school teachers continue to spend 30 minutes every day recording the attendance of every student on the 'Nirantara' app on their mobile phones. They have also been asked to make use of their Android phones for recording their own attendance on the 'Kartavya' app. There are a total of 14 apps on their mobile phones, including those related to midday meals, scholarships, and special children, to which teachers have to upload information. With connectivity issues and mobile compatibility, teachers spend considerable time each day uploading information to these apps. This digital push by the government is coming at the cost of teaching hours, teachers say. "No thought is being given by the government to the loss of teaching hours that this digital push is leading to," said a government teacher from Dakshina Kannada.

Afshan Yasmeen
Raghava M.

PUBLIC NOTICE

We are undertaking a title investigation on the immovable property more fully described in the '**Schedule**' hereto and hereinafter referred to as '**Schedule Properties**'. The said title due diligence is being conducted for and on behalf of our Client who is desirous of entering into certain transaction in relation to the Schedule Properties. The present owners ('**Owners**') morefully described in the Schedule hereinbelow, have represented to our Client that they are the absolute owners of the Schedule Properties and have unrestricted rights of alienation over the same.

Notice is hereby given to the general public that any person/s other than the present Owners, asserting any right, title, charge, lien, claim/s or any interest whatsoever in respect of the Schedule Properties are hereby called upon to submit to the undersigned, their claim/s, if any, over the Schedule Properties or submit their objections, if any, to the aforementioned transaction. The said claim/s or objections must be in writing, together with documentary proof to support such claim/s or objections and must be delivered to us at the address given below within a period of **10 (ten)** days from the date of publication of this Notice. If no such claim/s or objections are received, it shall be deemed that no one else other than the Owner/s has/ have any right, title, interest or claim whatsoever in respect of the Schedule Properties and our Client would be at liberty to proceed with the said transaction in connection with the Schedule Properties.

SCHEDULE
(Description of the Schedule Properties)

All that piece and parcel of immovable properties all situated at Chikkaralagere Village, Sulibele Hobli, Hoskote Taluk, Bangalore Rural District, morefully described in the table below:

Sl. No.	Survey Number	Extent	Bounded on the				Present Owner
			East by	West by	North by	South by	
1.	49/1	11 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 50	Land bearing Survey No. 63	Land bearing Survey No. 48	Land bearing Survey No. 52	Mr. Munegowda CV (son of Mr. Venkategowda)
2.	50/1	11 Guntas	Thammarasanahalli Village boundary	Land bearing Survey No. 49	Land bearing Survey No. 48	Land bearing Survey No. 51	
3.	51/1	04.12 Guntas	Thammarasanahalli Village boundary	Land bearing Survey No. 52	Land bearing Survey No. 50	Land bearing Survey No. 53	
4.	52/1	13 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 51	Land bearing Survey No. 62	Land bearing Survey No. 49	Land bearing Survey No. 53	
5.	53/1	07.08 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 53/2	Land bearing Survey No. 55	Lands bearing Survey Nos. 53 and 52	Land bearing Survey No. 54	
6.	53/2	07.08 Guntas (excluding 02 Guntas 'A' Kharab)	Land bearing Survey No. 53/3	Land bearing Survey No. 53/1	Lands bearing Survey Nos. 53 and 52	Land bearing Survey No. 54	
7.	53/3	07.08 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 53/4	Land bearing Survey No. 53/2	Land bearing Survey No. 51	Land bearing Survey No. 54	
8.	54/1	04.04 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 54/2	Land bearing Survey No. 55	Land bearing Survey No. 53	Chikkaralagere Village Boundary	
9.	54/2	04.04 Guntas	Land bearing Survey No. 54/3	Land bearing Survey No. 54/1	Land bearing Survey No. 53	Chikkaralagere Village Boundary	
10.	54/4	04.04 Guntas	Chikkaralagere Village Boundary	Land bearing Survey No. 54/3	Land bearing Survey No. 53	Chikkaralagere Village Boundary	
11.	63	17 Guntas	Lands bearing Survey Nos. 49 and 52	Land bearing Survey No. 55	Land bearing Survey No. 62	Land bearing Survey No. 53	
12.	56/1	21 Guntas	Lands bearing Survey No. 55	Lands bearing Survey Nos. 55 and 56/2	Land bearing Survey No. 62	Chikkaralagere Village Boundary	Mr. Devaraja N (son of Mr. Narayanaswamy)

Sd/-
Mr. Srinivas B.R., Partner
DSK Legal,
Prestige Loka, No. 201, 2nd Floor, No. 7/1 & 7/7,
Brunton Road, Bengaluru – 560025, Tel: 080-69548770.

Date : 28.09.2026
Place : Bengaluru

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

SAD DEMISE

B.KAMALA (97 years)
Fondly Kamalamma of Chinmaya Mission General Manager (Retd.), Canara Bank
Attained Heavenly Abode on 27.09.2026 at Srinagar Colony, Saidapet, Chennai
Your prayers will serve as acknowledgement
Deeply Mourned by Family Members
Mob: 88389 20144 / 97909 90668

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

First Anniversary

C P RADHA
(Radha Jayalakshmi - Carnatic Musicians)
Deeply mourned by Sumathi Rangarajan (Sister) Karthik Rangarajan (Nephew)
Ph: 75500 90231

‘Cancer, kidney, AIDS drugs sold at up to 70 times procurement cost’

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Pointing out that high-cost medicines used to treat cancer, kidney ailments, and AIDS are being sold at prices up to “70 times higher” than the rates at which dealers and stockists procure them, Karnataka Health Minister U.T. Khader has written a letter to Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda, seeking national action against “abnormal gaps” in drug prices.

The Minister said dealers and stockists purchase advanced pharmaceuticals from manufacturers at heavily discounted wholesale landed rates, while the MRPs printed on the medicines are fixed at “inflated, highly disproportionate levels”. The letter said the gap between the procurement price and MRP was “sometimes 30 times to more than 70 times”.

Mr. Khader said that the issue was particularly concerning for in-patients, emergency and intensive-care patients, oncology patients, and those requiring implants, surgical consumables, and other hospital-based treatment, as they cannot realistically compare suppliers or defer purchases.

The letter said that while the existing MRP framework prevents medicines from being sold above the printed MRP, it does not address situations where the MRP itself has little relation to the actual institutional transaction price, adding that hospitals retain an excessive undis-



U.T. Khader

closed margin.

Mr. Khader sought a national study comparing the printed MRP, manufacturer/importer price, hospital’s net acquisition price, and the price ultimately billed to patients for selected high-value medicines, medical devices, and consumables. He also proposed that the patient-facing price of products supplied through hospitals be capped at the lower end of the applicable statutory price, MRP or the hospital’s net acquisition cost plus a notified and reasonable service margin and applicable taxes.

The Minister said Karnataka would “cooperate with any pilot or national framework” and could, within its powers, make private hospitals disclose more information, require detailed bills for patients, and set up a system to handle complaints locally. However, he said the Centre needs to fix the basic problem – the large difference between what hospitals pay for medicines, the MRP printed on them and what patients are finally charged.

ED report no basis for FIR in CMRL case: Keralam Minister

The agency has sought FIR against Pinarayi, daughter, and son-in-law; Home Minister says State govt. decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry as there was lack of clarity on certain aspects

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday said that an FIR cannot be lodged against Leader of the Opposition and Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and her husband and CPI(M) State secretary member P.A. Mohamed Riyas merely on the basis of a proposal from the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The agency has alleged that CMRL made fraudulent payments of ₹2.78



State’s stand: Inquiry was ordered based on the Advocate General’s advice in the CMRL pay-off case, said Ramesh Chennithala. H. VIBHU

crore to Ms. Veena’s now-defunct company Exalogic Solutions under the guise of “IT consultancy services”. The ED had sought registration of a case based on “evidence” gathered during its probe and searches conducted under

the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

Mr. Chennithala told presspersons that the State government recently ordered a preliminary inquiry into the issue based on the legal advice it received. “The government is not

No load-shedding for now, says George

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

Energy and Tourism Minister K.J. George on Sunday said that Karnataka is not facing a load-shedding situation at present and there is no immediate need to impose power cuts, even as the State is facing a shortage of about 1,000 MW.

‘Managing situation’

Speaking to reporters in Mysuru, Mr. George said that the Energy Department had been managing the electricity situation for

the past six to eight months by procuring additional power from other States.

“As of now, there is no need for load-shedding. If the demand goes up further in the coming days, the issue will be discussed with the Chief Minister and in the Cabinet, and a decision will be taken on whether to go for load-shedding,” he said.

He said Karnataka was procuring additional power from States such as Punjab, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh. However, several States were also facing a

power shortage owing to the poor monsoon.

“If we seek 500 MW, we are getting only 50 or 100 MW. Our thermal plant at Raichur is undergoing repairs. Owing to cloudy weather and reduced wind, power generation from renewable energy sources has also declined. Nevertheless, we are managing the situation,” he said.

Mr. George said the demand for electricity was increasing and acknowledged that there had been an issue with power supply for two days. Irrigation

opposed to registering an FIR. But we decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry based on the Advocate General’s advice as there was a lack of clarity on certain things,” he said.

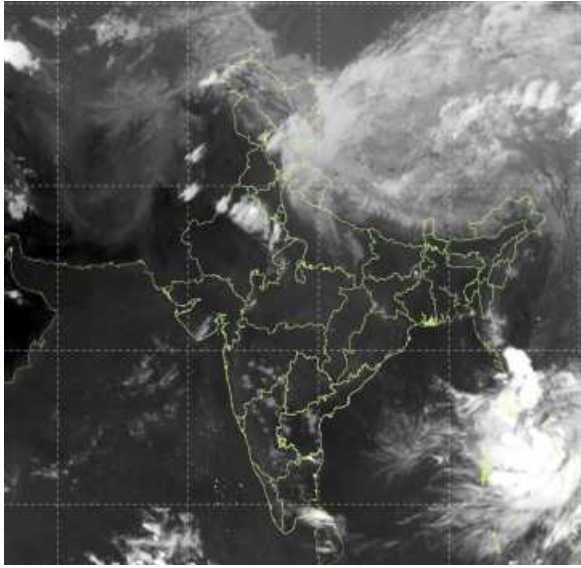
High Court directive

He said that the government had placed its stand in the Kerala High Court.

The High Court, on Saturday, directed the ED to submit the records it had provided to the Kerala Police while recommending registration of a case against Mr. Vijayan and his family. The court will hear the matter next on September 29. (With inputs from PTI)

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Karnataka and Uttarakhand. Thundersquall with wind speed reaching 50-60kmph very likely at isolated places over Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		35.1	26.2	Kurnool		36.0	25.1
Ahmedabad		34.7	25.0	Lucknow	36.0	24.0	21.2
Aizawl	4.0	31.5	21.4	Madurai		39.5	25.6
Bengaluru		31.3	20.2	Mangaluru		30.1	22.7
Bhopal			22.2	Mumbai	0.4	32.1	
Bhubaneswar	2.1	33.6	24.6	Mysuru		30.8	18.8
Chandigarh		30.4	22.2	New Delhi	4.0	30.2	21.2
Chennai		36.7	27.2	Patna	61.2	32.0	32.0
Coimbatore		34.8	21.6	Port Blair		29.9	29.9
Dehradun	24.6	18.4	21.1	Prayagraj	14.3	29.4	22.2
Gangtok		24.2	16.7	Puducherry		37.1	37.1
Goa				Pune		32.0	22.3
Guwahati		34.2	25.4	Raipur		31.0	31.0
Hubballi		32.0	19.0	Ranchi		33.0	29.3
Hyderabad		33.3	23.4	Shillong		24.0	24.0
Imphal		33.3	21.7	Shimla		24.2	16.0
Jaipur		22.7		Srinagar		29.8	29.8
Kochi		31.2	25.8	Thiruvananthapuram		32.4	32.4
Kohima	7.0	25.0	18.3	Tiruchirappalli		38.5	38.5
Kolkata	31.1	32.4	26.8	Vijayawada			
Kozhikode		35.0	24.9	Visakhapatnam		33.0	26.5

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		15	17	48	56	102	In observation made at 4.00 p.m.,
Bengaluru		27	63	43	62	120	Gummidipoondi, Tamil
Chennai		43	10	15	43	97	Nadu recorded an overall
Delhi							air quality index (AQI)
Hydrabad		13	23	52	54	98	score of 174 indicating an
Kolkata		9	20	34	51	72	unhealthy level of
Lucknow		10	25	15	15	28	pollution. In contrast,
Mumbai		3	17	13	41	93	Madikeri, Karnataka
Pune			31	65	35	72	Tiruchirappalli
Visakhapatnam		10	62	46	79	137	recorded a healthy AQI score of 15.

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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Padmakumar Nair

Few topics in higher education receive as much attention as industry-academia collaboration. Every policy document, accreditation framework, and university strategy seems to ask the same question: What must universities do differently to become more relevant to industry?

How practical is it?

While it is an important question, I increasingly wonder whether we have been asking the wrong one. Over the years, we have created an idealised picture of university-industry collaboration.

Every student should complete a meaningful internship. Every professor should work on industry-sponsored research. Universities and companies should jointly develop products, technologies, and services. Graduates should seamlessly transition into employment. It is an inspiring vision, but is it practical?

According to the All-India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), India produces around one crore graduates every year. But the country generates only about 10 to 15 lakh entry-level graduate jobs annually. The economy, undoubtedly, creates many more jobs, but relatively few are high-skilled positions requiring a university degree.

This mismatch fundamentally changes the discussion. Even if every company genuinely wanted to

The collaboration conundrum

Are industry-academia partnerships practical or a romantic dream?



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

collaborate with universities, can industry realistically provide quality internships for millions of students every year? Can companies dedicate engineers, managers, scientists, and designers to mentor such numbers? Can every faculty member undertake industry-funded research? Can every university sustain advanced laboratories capable of supporting collaborative product development?

Meaningful collaboration depends on several

important preconditions. Students must possess sufficient technical competence before entering the industry.

Capacity matters

Companies must have the organisational bandwidth to supervise interns and collaborative projects. Faculty members must be engaged in high-quality research that industry finds valuable. Universities must possess research infrastructure, labs, and administrative systems capable

of supporting sustained partnerships.

Internationally, countries such as Germany, Japan, South Korea, and several European nations have built stronger university-industry ecosystems that evolved through decades of sustained industrial development, strong research universities, and carefully designed public policies.

Even the U.S., often regarded as the benchmark for innovation, does not achieve the universal mo-

del of industry-academia collaboration that many discussions implicitly assume. Outstanding partnerships are concentrated in particular universities, industries, and research-intensive institutions rather than being the norm across the entire higher education system.

Questions to ask

Perhaps, then, the issue is not that universities are underperforming but that our expectations are unrealistic. This suggests that it is time to ask: What exactly are we trying to achieve? Is the primary objective employability, innovation, technology transfer, entrepreneurship, regional economic development, or workforce readiness?

Different goals require different models of collaboration. A single framework cannot serve every discipline or institution.

The second question is how we incentivise companies to collaborate with universities. Industry cannot be expected to collaborate simply because policymakers encourage it. Companies invest time and resources when they perceive clear value, whether through access to talent, cutting-edge research, intellectual property, or long-term competitiveness.

Finally, the most practical question of all: if deep industry collaboration cannot realistically reach every student, how should universities prepare graduates for successful careers? Perhaps the answer

lies less in attempting to replicate industry inside the university and more in developing graduates who can learn quickly after entering the workforce.

The future belongs to graduates who possess strong analytical ability, excellent communication skills, teamwork, intellectual humility, ethical judgement, and the capacity for lifelong learning. Technical knowledge will matter, but the ability to continuously acquire new knowledge may matter even more.

Industry-academia collaboration should certainly be expanded wherever it creates genuine value. It remains indispensable for research-intensive universities, innovation ecosystems, and technology-driven sectors. However, it should not become the sole measure of educational quality or institutional success.

The future of higher education will depend not merely on increasing the quantity of collaboration between universities and industry, but on designing

models that are realistic, scalable, and aligned with the needs of both.

Perhaps the time has come to stop asking how universities can become more like industry and, instead, ask a more fundamental question: What kind of graduates does society need, and what is the most practical way to prepare them?

Views expressed are personal

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Thapar Institute of Engineering and Technology.

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India's institutions have largely held except in dark periods such as the Emergency, when an executive emboldened by legislative strength ran roughshod over the Constitution and a shamelessly permissive judiciary let it do so via *ADM Jabalpur*. The ECI under Mr. Kumar has overseen the removal of more than 13 crore names from draft rolls through the SIR which, as this daily has repeatedly argued, shifts the onus of enrolment from the state to the elector, deletes names before it verifies and imposes onerous conditions for re-entry. It got away with this because the Supreme Court declined for months to decide whether the exercise was constitutional. When it finally ruled on May 27, the SIR was already a settled fact in Bihar, West Bengal and other Phase 2 States. The judgment, reminiscent of *ADM Jabalpur*'s deference to the state, engaged the SIR in theory and not in practice. It read a provision for exceptional, targeted revisions as a licence for a State-wide sweep. While it assured voters already on the rolls that they were still presumed eligible, the SIR made them prove it all over again. And it brushed aside its 1995 ruling that every removal must be individually reasoned. Events since then indicate the damage done – over nine in 10 appeals decided by West Bengal's tribunals have restored voters months after the Assembly polls; and in one third of Delhi's seats, the draft rolls have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025. The ECI's press note changes very little. The ECI must be reconstituted by a selection committee that does not give the government an overriding majority. Anything less would be a travesty of institutional democracy.

As the U.S. and China recalibrate ties,
implications for other nations are huge

The model outcomes from the Xi visit should not obscure the broader shift that recent U.S.-China engagement has underlined. The agreement between the world's two biggest powers to pursue what they call a constructive relationship of strategic stability based on fairness, respect and reciprocity points to a new equilibrium. Their relationship certainly remains beset by serious structural challenges and will remain one marked by rivalry. At the same time, both sides appear eager to set a floor to ensure a rivalry that is more managed, stable and predictable. Countries in the region will be watching closely how this may temper an "America First" Washington's appetite to push back against China in waters far from home. New Delhi will need to carefully watch this evolving new equilibrium. The recent U.S. tariff threats aimed at India have offered a stark contrast to the measured language with which Washington has been engaging Beijing. For long, a strand of Indian strategic thinking has been predicated on the assumption that U.S. strategy in the region was centred on the idea of a relationship with India as a bulwark against Chinese influence. That assumption increasingly appears open to question.

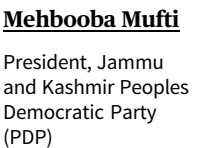
The aspiration-reality gap

The smartphone revolution has intensified this challenge. A young person in a town or remote village can now see within seconds how the rest of the world lives, studies, works and travels. Global possibilities are visible on high-definition screens, even as tangible opportunities remain painfully out of reach.

This has created a widening divide between aspiration and reality. The horizons of young Indians have expanded far faster than the institutions and economies around them. Access to higher education has widened, yet meaningful employment opportunities have not kept pace. A college degree is no longer a guarantee of a job, leaving many without financial security or the dignity that comes with economic independence. When heightened aspirations collide with limited opportunities, frustration inevitably follows, often finding expression in protests over recruitment, examination irregularities, examination and test paper leaks, unemployment and systemic failures.

Kashmiri youth share these aspirations but carry a compounding historical burden. Decades of conflict, political uncertainty and economic isolation have deepened their sense of insecurity and constrained their opportunities. Too often, young Kashmiris have been viewed through a narrow security lens, as potential liabilities rather than national assets.

Yet, Jammu and Kashmir, like the rest of India, has a large young population with its own aspirations. Its youth seek the same basic things as young people elsewhere: economic



Reconnecting Kashmir's historic routes could unlock economic opportunities for its youth

Focus on Kashmir's historic crossroads

For centuries, Kashmir was never a cul-de-sac. It was a thriving crossroads. Historic caravan routes linked Kashmir and Ladakh with Central Asia, Tibet and the broader Indian subcontinent. These routes carried far more than merchandise. They connected people, ideas, philosophies, literature, cultures and skills. The arrival of Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani, revered as Shah-i-Hamadani, is deeply embedded in Kashmiri history and is traditionally associated with the arrival of Persian and Central Asian craftsmen who enriched Kashmir's celebrated handicraft traditions. The historical lesson is clear: connectivity creates economic ecosystems.

Today, Indian strategic thinking needs to look beyond the immediate constraints posed by the Line of Control with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control with China. Where political and security conditions permit, India needs a pragmatic framework to gradually restore Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh to the role they historically occupied: that of a bridge connecting South Asia with Central Asia and the wider Eurasian landmass.

For this, India needs a diplomatic road map alongside its infrastructure road map. Reopening traditional routes towards Pakistan or Central Asia cannot happen without sustained engagement with neighbouring countries. With Pakistan, the objective should be to explore confidence-building measures and trade connectivity wherever feasible. With China, India should pursue practical dialogue on trans-Himalayan connectivity wherever economic interests and security concerns can be reconciled.

This transition could begin with a phased connectivity strategy. India should identify historically important trade corridors that could eventually be revived as modern economic corridors, beginning with those where security and diplomatic conditions are most conducive. This does not mean opening every route at once.

A road to opportunity

A functioning land corridor creates opportunities at every stage, from construction, transport and warehousing to hospitality, manufacturing, agriculture, logistics, finance, technology and services. Unlike air connectivity, whose economic benefits are concentrated around a limited number of nodes, a trade corridor can generate economic activity across a wider geography through which it passes.

Most importantly, it could give the young people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh something far more valuable than another promise. It could give them wings to fly towards new horizons.

India's demographic advantage is a window of opportunity, not a permanent condition. We cannot afford to allow a generation to grow up watching possibilities on smartphones while encountering closed doors in the real world.

For Jammu and Kashmir, the answer may lie partly in reopening doors that history once kept open. The Silk Road was never only about silk. It was about the movement of goods, people, ideas and possibilities.

It is time to view Kashmir not merely through the prism of conflict, but through the lens of enterprise, connectivity and integration. Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee spoke of abandoning beaten paths and searching for new ways to address difficult issues. The ancient road across the Himalayas do not belong merely in history books. Reimagined as modern economic arteries, they could become pathways to opportunity, giving the next generation not another reason to wait, but a road towards a better future.

G. Venkat Raman
Professor, Humanities
and Social Sciences,
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Management, Indore,
Madhya Pradesh

The challenge beyond factories

BYD's expansion in Europe illustrates one response. As it builds manufacturing capacity in Hungary, the company is also developing relationships with European suppliers. Xpeng has chosen another route, contracting Canadian automotive supplier Magna to assemble its vehicles in Austria. The two approaches differ, but they expose the same underlying problem: reproducing outside China is easier than reproducing outside China, the ecosystem that made production in China efficient in the first place.

What makes these ecosystems difficult to unwind or reproduce is that they consist of more than identifiable suppliers. They embody accumulated relationships between firms, specialised skills, tooling and production knowledge, logistics networks, and the ability of suppliers to respond quickly when designs or production volumes change. Many of these advantages are built through repeated interaction rather than formal contracts. This is why replacing an individual Chinese supplier does not necessarily eliminate dependence on the wider Chinese production system – and why transplanting a Chinese factory abroad does not automatically transplant the capabilities surrounding it.

Seen from this perspective, de-Sinification has a less obvious, two-sided character. Foreign firms attempting to reduce their exposure to China confront the depth of China's integration into their production networks. Chinese firms going global confront the difficulty of reproducing abroad the ecosystem on which their competitiveness depends. One side is trying to

What India needs to note, must build

This distinction matters particularly for India. The reorganisation of production is already creating openings. Japan's TDK has expanded its battery production in Haryana, deepening an Indian manufacturing base that it has been developing as part of its broader China-plus-one strategy. Murata Manufacturing, another Japanese electronic-component maker, is expanding its manufacturing presence in India. These investments show that India is beginning to receive parts of production ecosystems previously concentrated in China. But making the most of this opening requires more than attracting individual factories. India needs domestic suppliers capable of meeting demanding cost, quality and delivery standards, alongside reliable logistics, skilled workers and access to critical inputs. The test is whether new investments progressively deepen linkages with Indian firms and bring specialised capabilities and intermediate production into the domestic economy. The same principle should inform Chinese investment: its value should be judged partly by the capabilities and supplier networks it develops locally. India's opportunity is to convert the movement of factories into the gradual accumulation of an industrial ecosystem of its own.

The emerging geography of global production will therefore be shaped by more than decisions over where to locate factories. It will depend on whether the ecosystems behind those factories can be dismantled, transferred or rebuilt. De-Sinification may be visible in new factory locations and investment announcements, but its real test lies deeper within the production system. Factories can cross borders relatively quickly; industrial ecosystems, built through accumulated capabilities and relationships, are far less mobile.

A credibility crisis

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s decision to undertake a special drive to help those left out of the SIR and make changes in its functioning is clearly a response to the investigation by The Indian Express and the brickbats that followed from the Opposition. But it would be premature to see this as a change of heart. The ECI's handling of various issues so far has raised serious

questions about its independence and sensitivity to public concerns. As a constitutional body, it was expected to function with the fierce independence seen during T.N. Seshan's tenure. Instead, a widespread perception prevails that it has become vulnerable to political pressures. As a septuagenarian voter who values honesty and sincerity, I find it deeply

troubling that such independent institutions respond more to those in power than to the Constitution, their conscience and the collective will of the citizens.

V. Nagarajan,
Chennai

The reported dissent of two Election Commissioners over the functioning of the electoral-roll revision process raises serious

questions about the working of the electoral machinery. Concerns over ERO-Net access, changes to Form 6 and the exclusion of eligible voters cannot be treated lightly. Yet, recording dissent alone cannot end the responsibility of constitutional functionaries. If such irregularities were considered serious, the Commissioners ought to have pursued the available institutional mechanisms to

seek their resolution. Their failure to do so also raises questions about accountability within the institution entrusted with protecting the integrity of the electoral process.

Kanhaiya Pandey,
Giridih, Jharkhand

The exposure of 14 instances of objections to unilateral decisions concerning electoral rolls points to an assault on our democracy. However, a

bureaucrat does not
weaponise a constitutional
body in a vacuum. There
appears to be a conspiracy
to engineer poll outcomes
from behind the scenes. If
constitutional institutions
are compromised, those
responsible must face legal
consequences to restore
trust.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to
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must carry the postal address.

The pitfalls of mandatory FIRs

On August 5, the Supreme Court, in *G. Ganesh v. State of Tamil Nadu and Others*, reiterated that the police must register an FIR upon receiving any information about a missing ‘person’. The court clarified that the expression ‘person’ did not refer only to missing children but included every person.

The Supreme Court in May issued certain directions which inter alia included setting up a special portal by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) dedicated to human trafficking, registration of an FIR without waiting for any preliminary enquiry or leaving it to the guardians or family of the missing person to first search for him/her, activating the anti-human trafficking units (AHTUs) of districts, restoring the recovered child to the rightful guardian in accordance with law and Aadhaar verification or issuance of an Aadhaar card.

Presumption for children

The directions issued in *G. Ganesh* are no different from the directions issued by the Supreme Court in *Bachpan Bachao Andolan (BBA) versus Union of India and Others* in January 2013, in which the court was dealing only with ‘missing children’. The court then issued two directions. The first related to mandatory recording of FIR so that police authorities are activated in taking steps to trace the child. Second, the court asked each State to set up a Special Juvenile Police Unit at every police station in accordance with the provisions of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Rules, 2007.

In May 2013, when Madhya Pradesh expressed



RK Vij

is a former IPS officer

some doubt with respect to the provisions of Section 154 CrPC (now Section 173 BNSS), which relates to information in cognisable cases, the court said that there will be an initial presumption of either abduction or trafficking, unless, in the investigation, the same is proved otherwise.

Second, at least one specially trained police officer at each police station was directed to be designated as a Juvenile Welfare Officer as per Section 63 of the JJ Act, 2000. In case a missing child is not recovered within four months from the date of the FIR, the matter is to be forwarded to the AHTU.

While, in the case of a missing child, the presumption of a cognisable offence to set the law in motion is understandable, as a child’s consent has no relevance in law, such a presumption may be problematic when an adult leaves the house of his or her own volition.

Adults have agency

It is a matter of common knowledge that many adults leave their homes to live together as partners or get married without the consent of their parents. But in some cases, couples have been killed (in the name of family honour) after being found, with or without the assistance of the police.

It is also undisputed that initially every such case is reported as a missing-person case. If an FIR is registered in every case, it will become the duty of the police to trace such couples or an adult and hand them over to their parents. A person may leave information indicating his or her willingness before leaving, but the police would

still trace them to verify it. Thus, consenting couples may still face unnecessary police investigation.

The case of *G. Ganesh* involved a one-year-and-10-month-old child who went missing from Chennai in 2011, following which a ‘child missing’ case was registered. The case was transferred first to the Central Crime Branch and then to a Special Investigation Team, but the child remained untraced for 14 years. The petitioner alleged that the MHA guidelines issued in June 2013 for missing children were not followed and that the case was not transferred to the AHTU after four months. The Madras High Court dismissed the petition in March 2025, holding that the police had made all efforts to trace the child and that the 2013 guidelines were not applicable in 2011.

There was no occasion for the Supreme Court to *suo motu* take up the issue of missing adults. The May judgment also does not indicate that the States were heard on the issue. While the court’s intention to deal firmly with human trafficking cannot be doubted, not allowing even a small window for the police to conduct a preliminary enquiry is difficult to fathom. A week or fortnight could allow the police to filter cases where there is credible information that the person reported missing was neither abducted nor trafficked. A blanket presumption of kidnapping or trafficking in every case of a missing adult, without any evidence, is against the spirit of the statute. To that extent, the court needs to review its direction mandating the registration of an FIR.

Form 26 and the statutory mandate

On June 12, the Supreme Court dismissed the petition filed by Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan challenging the Returning Officer’s decision, rejecting her nomination for the Rajya Sabha election from Madhya Pradesh. The Returning Officer held that Natarajan had failed to disclose, in her Form 26 affidavit, a pending criminal complaint against her and had thereby suppressed material information.

The criminal complaint, instituted in 2025, alleged that Natarajan failed to take appropriate action against a party leader accused of misconduct. The case raises important questions about the scope of the disclosure obligations imposed on electoral candidates and the constitutional remedies available when nomination papers are rejected.

History of legislation

The statutory obligation requiring electoral candidates to disclose their criminal antecedents is of relatively recent origin. Parliament in 2002 inserted Section 33-A into the Representation of the People Act, 1951, or ROPA. The legislative amendment was prompted by the top court’s landmark decision in *Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms* (2002), where the court held that mandatory disclosure neither imposed an additional qualification for contesting elections nor conflicted with the scheme of the ROPA. Rather, it advanced the electorate’s right to make an informed choice and strengthened the purity of the electoral process.

Pursuant to the judgment, the Election



Vanshaj Azad

is an advocate based in New Delhi. Presently, he is working as a Law Clerk-cum-Research Associate at the Supreme Court of India

Commission was directed to mandate disclosure of specified criminal antecedents, assets, liabilities and educational qualifications through an affidavit. The government subsequently introduced Sections 33-A, 33-B, 75-A and 125-A into ROPA and amended the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, prescribing Form 26 as the affidavit to accompany every nomination paper.

Form 26 was initially aligned with Section 33-A; a significant departure occurred in 2018. Paragraph 5 of the Form was amended to require disclosure of all pending criminal cases, whereas Section 33-A mandates disclosure only of those cases involving offences punishable with imprisonment of two years or more in which charges have already been framed by a competent court.

It is this apparent divergence between the parent statute and delegated legislation that lies at the heart of the present controversy.

Disclosure mandate

The disclosure requirement is operationalised through Rule 4A of the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, which requires every candidate to file an affidavit in Form 26 along with the nomination papers. Rule 4A, however, is merely a procedural mechanism for implementing Section 33A and thus, it cannot become an independent source of substantive obligations. Yet, the 2018 amendment to Form 26 appears to do precisely that. Paragraph 5 now requires disclosure of all pending criminal cases, regardless of whether charges have been framed. The constitutional

question, therefore, extends beyond Natarajan’s candidature. Can delegated legislation, under the guise of prescribing the manner of disclosure, enlarge a substantive statutory obligation?

Constitutional remedies

While describing Article 32, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar famously called it the “heart and soul” of the Constitution. However, while dismissing Natarajan’s challenge to the rejection of her nomination, the top court relied upon the Constitution Bench decision in *N.P. Ponnuswami v. Returning Officer* (1952), which held that Article 329(b) bars judicial intervention in electoral disputes once the election process has commenced, leaving an election petition as the exclusive post-election remedy.

Natarajan’s case exposes the limits of that doctrine. Should the constitutional remedies under Articles 32 and 226 remain unavailable even where the Returning Officer’s decision is alleged to be manifestly arbitrary or patently without jurisdiction? Ponnuswami’s rationale was to prevent judicial intervention from interrupting the electoral process, not to insulate totally perverse administrative decisions.

Although Natarajan has been granted liberty to challenge her rejection through an election petition under Section 100 of ROPA, the broader constitutional question survives. It may be time for the Supreme Court to revisit *Ponnuswami* and clarify whether constitutional courts should remain powerless even in the face of patent arbitrariness during the electoral process.

Long wait for justice as pendencies in rape cases mount

Rape cases have remained steady since 2018, but pendency has grown, with less than 2% ending in conviction in the same year as the trial

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl on September 21 by three men who posed as police personnel at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir in South-east Delhi and social media videos from Bihar’s Jamui and Samastipur showing harassment of girls, have once again raised concerns about women’s safety in public spaces and the need for prompt and stringent preventive and punitive measures.

Legislative changes over the years, especially since the 2012 Nirbhaya rape case in Delhi, have introduced tougher punishments and set timelines for disposal of rape cases.

However, an analysis of rape cases from the reports of the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) shows that the country still has a long way to go in ensuring justice in a time-bound manner. (This analysis does not include rape cases filed under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, which are reported separately by the NCRB).

The country’s conviction rate of less than 30% of rape cases is already low, and analysis showed that even for those cases that result in conviction, the wait is usually long.

Chart 1 shows the number of cases of rape registered every year since 2018. This translates to an average of 84 cases per day and nearly three cases per hour.

Further data show that roughly 2% of the cases that were sent to trial ended in conviction within the same year.

This is quite low even if one were to assume that the cases that went to trial towards the end of the year could spill over to the subsequent year despite following legally mandated deadlines.

Though the number of new cases has fairly remained the same,

the pendency in the courts has consistently grown over the years, as shown in **Chart 2**.

Chart 3 illustrates how only a small fraction of cases entering the system result in conviction after trial within the same year. The chart shows data for 2024, the latest year for which the NCRB has released the data.

Nearly 40,000 cases were taken up for investigation in 2024, which included the 29,536 rape cases reported that year. The rest were predominantly cases pending from the previous year and a handful of cases that were reopened.

Of these cases in the investigation pool, about 25,000 (63%) were chargesheeted, while the rest ended up in the categories of pending police investigation, transfer of the case to another investigative agency, or disposal by the police if they found that the investigation did not warrant further proceedings.

Trial backlog

When the chargesheeted cases went to trial, they added to the lakhs of cases that were already in the trial backlog, bringing the total rape cases in the trial pool to 2,06,777 cases. Nearly 90% of these remained pending at the end of the year.

Of the rest of the 20,587 cases disposed of by the judiciary, nearly 68% were acquittals, 8% were discharged, and the remaining 24% ended up in convictions.

Only 421 of those cases resulted in convictions – which is just 2% of those taken up for trial that year and less than 1.5% of the total rape cases filed that year.

A look at the previous years also revealed similar patterns.

In 2023, only 2.3% of cases that went to trial ended up in conviction, while these figures for 2022 and 2021 respectively were 1.9% and 1.2%, which emphasise the need for additional measures beyond the legislative amendments to ensure time-bound delivery of justice.

Elusive justice

The data for the charts were sourced from National Crime Records Bureau’s annual Crime In India reports



Demanding safety: A college student holds a placard during a solidarity march demanding police action and better safety for women following the alleged gang-rape of a girl, in New Delhi, on September 23. REUTERS

CHART 1: Nearly 30,000 cases of rape were reported in India since 2018, averaging to around 80 rape cases a day

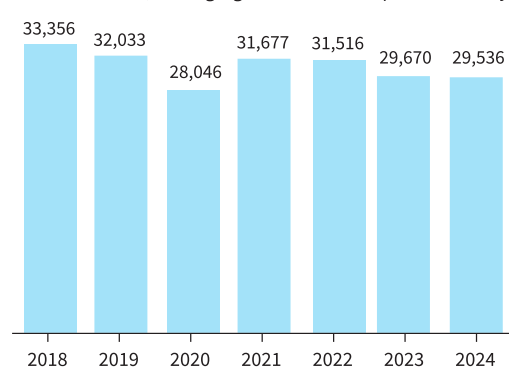


CHART 2: Status of rape cases that went to trial at the end of each year. Values above bars are cases pending trial

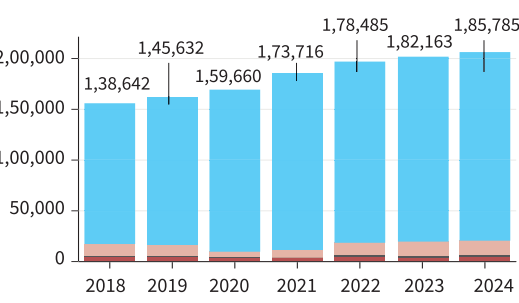
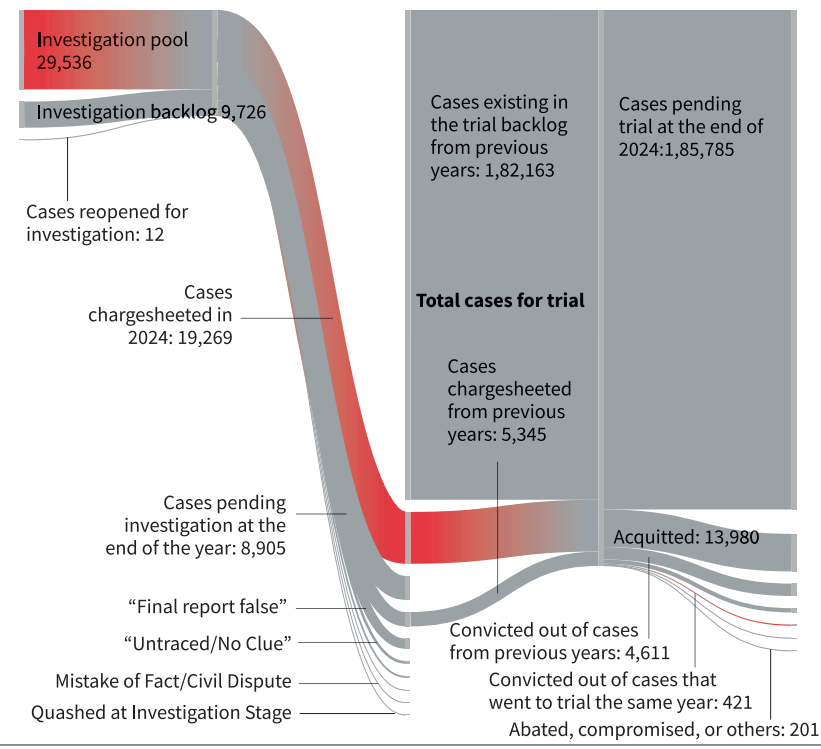
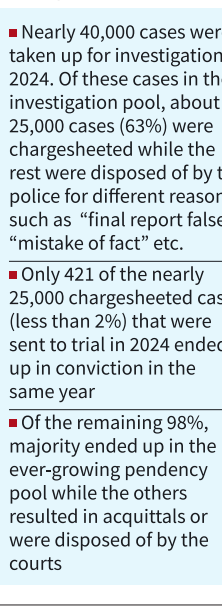


CHART 3: This shows how rape cases investigated in 2024 moved from the police to the judiciary, with many adding to the pendency backlog



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 28, 1976

Electricity from Hotwater Springs

Manikaran (Kulu), Sept. 27: Hotwater springs that local people bathe and wash in and use to cook food might one day help light up their homes. “We are looking for steam in the area”, says Mr. Zahir Alam, Chief of the drilling operations of the Geological Survey of India project at Manikaran.

“Once we hit steam, it can be harnessed to produce electricity”.

The geo-thermal project has been under way for over a year now and the workers have bored about a dozen holes, up to 200 metres deep, in Manikaran and neighbouring Rasoi, but with little luck. Researchers in snow-laden areas of Ladakh have been able to grow cauliflower and strawberries by using heat from these springs to maintain optimal temperature in hothouses, known as greenhouses.

Elsewhere, they have been used in place of electricity to operate refrigeration plants.

Scientists offer four possible explanations for the age-old natural phenomenon: underground radioactivity, some strong chemical reaction, movement of the earth’s crust, or the water coming into contact with magma – red-hot rocks in the earth’s womb.

But the local people have another tale handed down to them over the centuries.

Lord Shiva’s consort, Parvati, once, it seems, dropped a necklace bead into a pond, where the serpent god, Vasuki, gulped it. Shiva naturally asked Vasuki to return the ornament, and when the latter refused, the Lord glared at the pond in such rage that the water in it began to boil. Poor Vasuki quickly turned over the bead. He was perhaps spared further agony, but the water in the area is still bubbling. Hot springs burst forth almost wherever one digs.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 28, 1926

Rs. Two for a copper

Colombo, Sept. 27: An amazing story gained considerable credence in Colombo to-day that the Treasury was offering two rupees for every cent bearing 1924 date. It was believed that in making cents at the mint, a quantity of gold was mixed with copper. Many people called demanding rupees two. The story was circulated either as legpull or for the purpose of getting money from credulous persons. Some boutique keepers made a profit in selling 1924 cents.

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CPI(M) leader, AAP chief discuss EC row, ED action against ex-Keralam CM

Mamata camp leader faces attack twice in two days

Congress to hold self-respect meet over 'purification' ritual

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI to stay SIR, start *suo motu* proceedings on EC conduct

BJP slams Rahul over SIR, accuses Opposition parties of maligning institutions

A THRONE WITHOUT RIVALS



INBRIEF



3-storey building collapses in Haryana, 4 dead, 12 injured

Four people died while more than ten were injured when a three-storeyed building under construction collapsed at Dhulkot village near Ambala City in Haryana on Sunday, officials said. The incident unfolded in the late afternoon when the concrete slab (lintel) for the roof was being cast on the first floor, prompting locals to initiate rescue efforts before informing the police and emergency services. One of the injured workers claimed that some labourers were working on the ground floor, while others were engaged in the casting work above. Ambala Civil Surgeon Renu Beri told reporters that 12 injured labourers were brought to the hospital, of whom five are still admitted, two were discharged on request, while the others were discharged after first aid. PTI

IndiGo A321 plane involved in another tail strike

An IndiGo Airbus A321 was involved in yet another tail strike at Bengaluru airport on Sunday, marking at least the ninth known such incident involving the airline's A321 fleet. In a statement, IndiGo said an "abnormal runway contact" occurred during "gusty wind conditions" in Bengaluru. The aircraft was operating a flight from Guwahati. It aborted its initial landing attempt at Bengaluru airport before making a final landing at 12.15 p.m., industry sources said. A tail strike occurs when the rear section of an aircraft comes into contact with the runway during landing, take-off, or a go-around.

Tribal students to embark on 180-km march to Mumbai

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
NASHIK

Hundreds of tribal students in Maharashtra will embark on a nearly 180-km march from Nashik to Mumbai on Monday, pressing the government to address their demands for better facilities, safety, and accountability in government-run residential schools.

Spearheaded by the Sakal Adivasi Vidyarthi Andolan Kruti Samiti, the long march comes 40 days after a sit-in at the Idgah Maidan in Nashik. The protest continues, with a small slate declaring the day of protest hanging from the ceiling of a temporary pandal. Posters of Birsu Munda, Bhagat Singh and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar surround the protesters as they take turns to sit on strike.

Among the demands of the protesters are the resig-



Tribal students at the sit-in at Nashik's Idgah Maidan. The protest has been going on for the past 40 days. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

nation of Maharashtra Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike, the transfer of the Tribal Development Department's Secretary and Commissioner, basic facilities in tribal schools and hostels, an independent inquiry into tribal students' deaths at residential schools, and financial assistance for victims.

"Last month, the government held discussions with protesters from Pune and Nagpur. Tribals from

Nashik did not join them. The government gave them false promises. We are in touch with tribals from Nashik, Khandesh, North Maharashtra, Marathwada, and Vidarbha. We expect around 1,500 students to join us on the first day of the protest march," tribal leader Rahul Pawra told *The Hindu*. Protesters also raised concerns over the food provided by central kitchens to tribal schools.

Student's death can't be seen in isolation: IIT-Bombay alumni

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande
MUMBAI

The death by suicide of Sahil Wakode cannot be viewed in isolation, alumni of Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay (IITB) said on Sunday. The incident pointed to a deeper problem within the academic environment, they said. In a letter written to the Director of the institute, a group of alumni have also expressed concerns over the increasingly "militarised campus" during exams. Calling for immediate, comprehensive reforms, they sought a survey of the students' mental health and a humane approach to deal with instances of misconduct.

The alumni expressed deep anguish about a series of deaths by suicide at the institute. The 10 de-

mands put forth by them include a call for an immediate and impartial investigation into specific allegations of caste-based harassment and improved mental health support, including mandatory faculty sensitisation.

"We sincerely hope that the institute will take concrete steps to ensure that the academic climate at IITB is egalitarian, humane and conducive to intellectual growth. This requires addressing the caste, class and gender-based inequalities... that are deeply embedded in our society and can manifest within academic institutions," the letter, accessed by *The Hindu*, stated.

[Those in distress may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline: 011-40769002.]

THE CROSSWORD+14909

(set by Dr. X)

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Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

Across

1 Where one sees the letter E explicitly? (2,2,4,5)

8 Advance to save boy in valley (5)

9 Delighted with production of oil by American plant (9)

11 Teen in inn excited about boy finally giving number (6-4)

12 Starts to appreciate fine African rhino from a distance (4)

14 Rose edited series about Greek mythological character (7)

16 Asserting briefly about making a bloomer (7)

17 Deceiver cheers up after ensnaring maiden (7)

19 Small tin can made of tin (7)

21 Lover starts to cuddle at first (4)

22 Liaison at rave after consuming cocaine - becoming rebellious (10)

25 Cause a commotion in bar, catching date embracing hot lady (5,4)

26 Lyric poet turned very tense, entertaining princess (5)

27 Art of artfully reshaping with latest in 3D CGI (7,6)

2 Runner's not at all well, close to collapse (7)

3 Love smart American couple welcoming members at launch individually (3,2,1,4)

4 Content of natural ginseng gum (5)

5 Desires remuneration after end of therapy (9)

6 Bishop, one wearing outsize sashes (4)

7 Model consuming ecstasy with posh fellow turned miserable (7)

8 Specialist beginning to chat about treatment of neurosis (11)

10 Knight in position trapping one's rook with clean moves (3,8)

13 Goad union's ridiculous dinosaurs (10)

15 Peaceful, having good time on island's national park (9)

16 Woman drinking wine, becoming more reckless (7)

18 Nudging to control one talking loudly (7)

23 Relaxed in food shop in retreat, cuddling date (5)

24 Look at bottom of pump for leak (4)

SUDOKU

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			2			6	7	8
		1		4	7		3	
	4	8		6		7		
9		2				5		4
		6		9		3	8	
	2		1	7		4		
7	1	5			9			
6								

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Rama's justification

Dharma is sukshma, its subtle meanings difficult to grasp. We should follow what our Acharyas advise us to follow, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. Only those who practise dharma must talk about it. Rama was qualified to talk about dharma, because He was a practitioner of dharma. Vaali questions the propriety of Rama's action of shooting an arrow at him (Vaali) from behind, and wonders if His act is dharmic. Rama explains what dharma is to Vaali. Vaali's foremost sin is misbehaviour towards Sugreeva's wife. Vaali is the elder brother of Sugreeva and is therefore like a father to him. He should have treated Sugreeva as he would his son. Would it be right for a man to make his son's wife his own? Vaali, by his conduct towards Sugreeva's wife, had committed a very grave sin. Just as one must not have lustful thoughts about one's daughter or sister, likewise one must not have such thoughts about one's brother's wife.

Having broken such a fundamental rule, how could Vaali talk about dharma and hope for clemency? Dharma sastras say that a king who metes out proper punishment for a crime or a sin will enter heaven. If a thief or a sinner is punished by his king, he escapes hell. But a king who fails to punish a wrongdoer will definitely go to hell, according to the dharma sastras. As for killing Vaali from behind, do hunters have to face animals before killing them, asks Rama. Vaali has been claiming that what he did was right according to vanara dharma. If he took refuge behind the argument that he was an animal, then using the same argument, Rama could say He was justified in hitting Vaali from behind.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

PM pays tribute to Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday paid tribute to former Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) international working president Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary, describing him as an "organisational genius" and recalling his "pivotal role" in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

In an op-ed article, Mr. Modi recalled his many interactions with Singhal, who was born on September 27, 1926, and passed away on November 17, 2015. "I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection," Mr. Modi wrote. "One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young Karyakarta going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him," he added. "Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible."

He recalled how he saw Singhal work hard on various projects that involved "long and often difficult travels".

"His mind was constant-

He hailed the former VHP international working president's 'pivotal role' in Ram Janmabhoomi movement

ly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society," Mr. Modi recalled. "Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding Karyakartas to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible."



Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system as a precautionary measure to address the issue. FILE PHOTO

Boeing finds glitch in guidance system of some 737-MAX planes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Boeing has detected a software issue in some of its B737-MAX planes that could result in disengagement of the automated flight guidance system after a missed landing approach, and the aircraft maker is working on a permanent solution, according to sources.

In India, there are 96 Boeing 737-MAX planes operated by Air India Express (53) and Akasa Air (43).

"Last month, we informed all 737 operators about a software issue where pilots may experience a reduction in automation during a landing scenario. We shared information with operators that reinforced existing pilot procedures for safely handling such cases," the spokesperson said in a statement.

Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system following a missed approach as a precautionary measure to address the issue, sources said.

"We are closely coordinating with Boeing and can confirm that there is no impact to the safety of Akasa Air operations. Our aircraft continue to operate safely in accordance with established procedures and applicable regulatory requirements," an airline

spokesperson said in a statement.

However, the carrier did not specifically mention whether any of its Boeing 737-MAX planes had been impacted due to the issue. There was no response from Air India Express.

There was no immediate response from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on whether it was probing the issue and whether any advisory was issued to airlines.

Fine print:
Barely read
and rarely
understood

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In one of the recent pieces on this page, I had emphasised that we must read and understand the insurance policy we are buying. Because once bought, the wording of the contract is binding. I got quite a few responses to that and the preceding pieces, all focusing on the effort needed to understand your policy.

One of them, from a smart neighbour, said, “Good points, Nitya. But for ordinary people there is so much fine print that it is boring. The language is confusing. If we get the non-negotiables as bullet points, it will be very easy to just see that those conditions are met and we can sign.”

She was so right, and yet wrong. They are all there. If we read them – labour over them, actually – we would probably piece together the broad picture. But understanding? That’s a different animal.

The information is all there. Lots of it, in fact. But its presence doesn’t equal comprehension.

What exactly do we mean by “understanding” a policy?

It is not recognising the words, though you will find quite a few that are centuries old.

It is not managing to finish the document, though that’s an achievement in itself. Why? The simplest policy is 12 pages long. And those are fine-print-in-9-point-font-and-double-column-format pages. I have even seen policies printed in blue font. Pretty but pointless.

It is not even being able to repeat what a clause says. I should be able to tell what it means for me, in a real situation, when I have a claim, for example.

I tried this in a formal setting. I gave a couple of bright ladies a hospitalisation policy document, asked them to read through it. One of them immediately asked, “Is this the Constitution?”

I must have looked confused so she pointed to the first paragraph of the document, “it says ‘Preamble’ she said. I peeked over to see what was on her page. It read, “This policy is a contract of insurance issued by XYZ Insurance Company Limited (hereinafter called the ‘Company’) to the proposer mentioned in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured’) to cover the person(s) named in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured Persons’)”.

Her next comment I could not but agree with. “Why do I need this?” she asked, genuinely puzzled. Why indeed.

Non-starter

If she had said she did not want to continue further, I would have understood perfectly. In fact, it happened with another person. Peering seriously for a few minutes at the blue-printed document she laid it down emphatically and said, “No, Nitya, I can’t do this.”

Forget reading it or discovering that insurance policies also have preambles, she just couldn’t physically read it. And this a self-taught veteran who handles property and stock market investments by herself.

There were other comments to come. When asked for first impressions on reading through a page or two, a gentleman remarked that it was written defensively, as if they rushing to make clear what they would not do.

Providing 40 pages of information does not necessarily mean the reader will understand it.

I will take you through the rocky path of trying to understand actual insurance policies in future installments of CoverNote.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, while PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH

A data-driven analysis
of mutual funds vs. PMS

Across a entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0% CAGR by 50 bps, ICRA and PMS Bazaar data show

WHITHER WEALTH

Rushabh Desai

In the Indian wealth management landscape, portfolio management services (PMS) are frequently positioned as a premium upgrade over equity mutual funds. Targeted at high-net-worth individuals (HNIs), PMS strategies theoretically promise bespoke strategy execution, unconstrained stock selection, and superior alpha generation. However, empirical market data evaluating returns over the long term reveals a more nuanced reality: higher entry tickets and concentrated strategies do not automatically translate to superior performance.

An analysis of 10-year annualised return distributions across 79 equity mutual funds (Regular Growth) and 73 equity PMS schemes spanning the Flexi Cap, Large & Mid Cap, Multi Cap, Mid Cap, and Small Cap categories provides critical data on how these two investment structures have actually performed over a decade.

According to data from ICRA and PMS Bazaar, as of August 31, 2026, equity mutual funds generated a higher 10-year average return compared with equity PMS strategies. Across the entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0%



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum

CAGR by 50 basis points. While the gap may appear modest on paper, it suggests that the higher ticket size and the higher risk taken in PMS strategies are not necessarily justified by the baseline returns. However, the average is the least interesting metric here; the real story lies in the return distribution between the two structures.

Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years.

In contrast, only 1% of mutual funds fell into this underperforming bracket. An investor choosing a random equity PMS strategy faced a 1-in-8 probability of delivering returns below target long-term risk-free rates plus inflation, whereas the regulatory diversification of mutual funds effectively insulated 99% of schemes above this threshold. An overwhelming majority of mutual funds (98% of all schemes) delivered solid wealth compounding



A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years. In contrast, only 1% of MFs fell into this underperforming bracket

between 10% and 20% CAGR (62% in the 10-15% bucket and 36% in the 15-20% bucket). In comparison, PMS strategies achieved a combined 84% in this range (51% in the 10-15% bucket and 33% in the 15-20% bucket). Ultimately, mutual funds demonstrated far higher consistency in hitting the median market growth corridor.

True advantage

However, PMS demonstrated its true structural advantage at the extreme top end of performance. Approximately 4% of PMS strategies generated blowout returns exceeding 20% CAGR over 10 years, compared to just 1% of mutual funds.

For investors seeking exceptional alpha generation, PMS offered a 4x higher probability of identifying top-decile outlier managers, though the absolute odds of landing there were still just 4 in 100. Understanding why these distributions diverge requires examining the regulatory frameworks and portfolio construction mechanics of both structures:

PMS portfolios typically hold concentrated bets. When top convictions pay off, PMS strategies can hit multi-bagger trajectories. Conversely, when core bets underperform, the lack of diversification leads to a severe long-term return drag.

Equity mutual funds operate under strict categorical mandates. PMS managers, on the other hand, possess near-total flexibility to move across cash, market-cap segments, and sectoral themes. While advantageous, this unconstrained tactical allocation increases the risk of human error, widening the performance dispersion.

PMS offerings frequently incorporate performance fees, management fees, and transaction charges that create higher hurdles for generating net alpha. Additionally, portfolio rebalancing in a PMS incurs direct capital gains tax events for the individual account holder, whereas mutual funds rebalance inside the pool tax-free.

None of this means PMS is a poor product; rather, it is a distinctly different structure that performs in cycles. Success requires thorough due diligence and selecting the right fund manager capable of capturing top-quartile concentrated upside over the medium to long term. In PMS strategies, poor manager selection can result in severe capital drag.

(The writer is Founder - Rupee With Rushabh Investment Services)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.75	10,550-12,093	2,110-2,419	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	Up to 0.25%
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.50-9.30	10,019 - 10,452	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
Federal Bank	7.90-9.00	10,114 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.55-9.65	10,031 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.63	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.30 - 9.35	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/customers with 6 months of relationship with bank
**50% waiver on processing fee till September 30
***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on September 23

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Managing
inflation
risk

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Both working executives and retirees are exposed to inflation risk, but retirees are affected more when price levels increase. In this article, we discuss inflation risk in relation to retirees and explore how they can manage this risk.

Hedging issue

Inflation risk is the likelihood that inflation is greater than expected. You will factor in inflation for determining your terminal wealth for a goal. If you are saving to fund your child’s college education, you will factor in education inflation to arrive at the amount you will need when your child enters college. Similarly, when you determine the amount you need at retirement, you must estimate the general inflation during your post-retirement years.

The risk you are exposed to is the likelihood that actual inflation will be greater than the expected inflation you factored into your retirement portfolio calculation.

Note that we are referring to general inflation that will affect your living expenses, not the health-care inflation.

The latter is typically more than double that of general inflation and can increase even when general inflation is in line with expectation.

If you are nearing retirement and are concerned about inflation risk, how should you manage the risk?

A hedge typically works when the investment product value rises in line with the increase in price level. Actual inflation can be greater than expected inflation because of rising commodity prices, especially crude oil.

So, you can buy investment products that take exposure to such commodities to hedge inflation risk. But products for the mass-affluent to hedge inflation risk are unavailable in India. Note that gold and equity investments may not be a good hedge against inflation.

Conclusion

Commodities futures typically offer a good hedge against inflation but have high downside risk and may be unsuitable for mass-affluent retirees. An alternative is rental property. Rental income may not be a hedge against inflation, but rentals can continually increase.

It is optimal to buy a new property just before retirement to earn market rentals. Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are an affordable alternative for those who do not want to invest lump-sum amount from their retirement corpus into rental properties. REITs are like mutual funds that invest in commercial properties to earn lease rentals.

As per SEBI regulation, REITs are required to distribute 90% of their net distributable income (lease rentals minus operating expenses) to their investors every year.

This provides for stable cash flows that could increase with inflation.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in. The experts on personal finance will answer select queries. Moneywise will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular.

BEIJING

China sends two giant pandas to U.S. following Trump-Xi summit



Two giant pandas sent by China arrived in the United States on Sunday, Beijing's state media said, after the Washington summit between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping. China loans the mammals as part of a "panda diplomacy" programme to foster foreign ties. The pandas will be hosted by the Atlanta zoo for 10 years. AFP

JOHANNESBURG

Police search for perpetrators after 27 die in shootings in South Africa



South African police were on Sunday searching for the perpetrators of two separate shootings that killed 27 people in Johannesburg and Cape Town, in the latest criminal violence to hit the country. President Cyril Ramaphosa said security forces "are going to continue pulling out all stops" to put an end to criminality. REUTERS

KATHMANDU

10 people missing after avalanche hits camp at Nepal's Himlung peak



At least 10 local climbers and guides are missing after an avalanche hit the base camp of the 7,126-metre tall Himlung peak in Nepal on Sunday, an expedition organiser said. The Himalayan country is already reeling from a devastating, tsunami-like flood on August 26 that killed more than 1,400 people and left over 6,000 missing. AFP

GENEVA

Swiss voters reject plan to toughen neutrality rules in key referendum



Swiss voters on Sunday rejected a plan to tighten their country's neutrality, dismissing an initiative championed by the hard-right. The proposal was rejected by 70.1% of voters, according to the final results. The proposal emerged following Switzerland's decision to join EU sanctions against Russia over its war in Ukraine. AFP

Iran stands firm on plan to reopen Hormuz after Trump rejects move

Tehran insists on diplomacy, but says it has never backed down from its rights; the proposal seeks cessation of all hostilities in the region, lifting of sanctions and release of frozen assets; U.S. envoy to the UN calls the deal cynical for asking too much

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON, TEHRAN

Iran stood firm on Sunday on its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. President Donald Trump's rejection of the proposal, leaving the war in West Asia locked in a stalemate.

Iran's plan called for a cessation of all hostilities in the region, including in Lebanon, according to Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, and a return to the conditions in the ceasefire deal that fell apart a few months ago.

That agreement had called for the release of frozen Iranian assets, the lift-



Ocean view: A boy stands with his bicycle on a beach overlooking vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas, Iran. AP

ing of sanctions on Iranian oil and an end to the U.S. naval blockade.

"Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening Hormuz is contingent upon these conditions being fulfilled.

But Mr. Trump said on Saturday that he rejected the truce deal. "They want to make a deal where they open the Strait immediately because they're losing so badly," he told reporters.

His Ambassador to the UN, Mike Waltz, accused Tehran of demanding too much in exchange for a return to the negotiating table. "This was, I think, a pretty cynical attempt to put something on the table that they knew was unacceptable. To ask for the release of the blockade, the sanctions, international sanctions and access to billions in assets, just to talk," he said.

Meanwhile, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said that

they seized an American submarine drone on Sunday in the Strait of Hormuz. It said the underwater vehicle was being used "for espionage purposes".

Economic isolation

Hailing new restrictions targeting Iran's airlines and banks, U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Saturday that Washington's efforts to pressure countries to economically isolate Iran was delivering results.

"At my direction, teams were dispatched across the globe to engage with countries and demand action against Tehran," he said on X. "These efforts are delivering results".

Israeli Minister calls for war in West Bank, seizure of Gaza areas

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich called on Sunday for the annexation of parts of south Lebanon and the Gaza Strip and for Israeli forces to "go to war" against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank.

"I would like us to annex at least as far as the yellow line in Gaza and as far as the Litani River in Lebanon... because if a war ends along the same lines where it began, what will deter the enemy from go-

ing to war again," Mr. Smotrich said.

"I think we need to go to war in Judea and Samaria, to dismantle the Palestinian Authority that supports terror," he added, using the biblical term for the West Bank. The Palestinian Authority condemned Mr. Smotrich's call for war in the West Bank.

Meanwhile, Gaza's Health Ministry said on Saturday that the Palestinian death toll rose to 74,016 people during the nearly three-year Israel-Hamas war.

Eight killed in Ukraine as Russia says it hit military infra, data centres, vessels

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Russian strikes killed eight people across Ukraine a day after Moscow vowed to achieve its war aims "no matter the circumstances", Ukrainian authorities said on Sunday.

Interior Minister Ivan Vyhivskiy said Russian strikes hit Sumy, killing three people including a 16-year-old girl.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said three people were killed in nighttime strikes in Zaporizhzhia and a drone strike had killed one man in Kyiv.



Mangled remains: A firefighter works at the site of a warehouse hit by a Russian drone strike in Kyiv, Ukraine on Sunday. REUTERS

"The enemy continues to relentlessly attack the Kyiv region with strike drones," the city's administration said.

Authorities in the Odesa

region said a "massive strike" on the south of the Black Sea region had killed one more person.

The Russian Defence Ministry said on Sunday its

forces struck two drone storages in Mykolaiv, the headquarters of a naval base and military stores in Kiliya port. A cargo ship carrying military goods to the port of Odesa was also struck, it said.

A Kyivstar data centre in Kyiv and another belonging to the Omega Telecom company was also bombed, it said.

The attacks came a day after Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov told the UN that Moscow intends to continue its military campaign "to the end". (With inputs from Reuters)

28 fighters 'sent from Pakistan' killed and 32 captured: Taliban

Associated Press
KABUL

Afghanistan's Taliban government said on Sunday that its forces killed 28 fighters and captured 32 others, including alleged members of the Islamic State group said to have crossed from Pakistan.

Taliban-run Defence Ministry said in a post on X that the fighters were killed or captured on Saturday in Kamdesh district in Nuristan. It alleged that several IS-affiliated groups had been sent from Pakistan

"with the aim of carrying out acts of subversion and creating insecurity."

Pakistan's Ministry of Information rejected the allegations as "frivolous, baseless and devoid of any truth."

Meanwhile, Pakistan's military said on Sunday that its forces had killed more than 71 militants in operations in Balochistan over the last 96 hours.

Tensions between the two countries have increased in recent days over cross-border fighting and Pakistani airstrikes.

Sport

Ishan scalps five, Cattle scores century

YOUTH TEST

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Ishan Om claimed a five-for to put India under-19 in command of the first Youth Test as it bowled Australia under-19 out for 217 on the opening day here on Sunday, despite a gritty century by Blake Cattle.

Walking in at 27 for three, the 17-year-old Cattle scored 102 (198b, 7x4).

Fruitful partnership

He found a solid partner in Zed Hollick (59, 160b, 7x4), and the pair added 147 for the fourth wicket.

Australia looked in control when Cattle and Hollick were going strong.

But their exits changed the course of the innings as Australia lost its last six



Standout performers: Ishan and Mohit struck at regular intervals. SAURASHTRA CRICKET ASSOCIATION

wickets for 43 runs. Ishan (five for 53) and Yashbardhan Chauhan (two for 56) exploited the lower-order.

In response, India ended the day at eight for no loss.

Opting to bat, Australia was in trouble as pacer Mohit Ulva (three for 37) and Ishan struck early.

Hayden Barbulovic,



Neel Patel and Matthew Lough failed to get going. But Cattle had other plans.

In the V

He settled in, playing in the V and rebuilding with Hollick.

India was dealt a blow when bowler Pranav Ravendra suffered an injury



Cattle. SHAYAN ACHARYA

and could just bowl 10 overs.

Ulva eventually broke the stand, having Hollick caught behind.

Cattle reached his hundred to a standing ovation but was cleaned up by Yashbardhan soon after. With Cattle and Hollick gone, Australia lost wickets in clusters. Ishan returned to complete his five-for as India seized control.

The scores: Australia u-19 217 in 86.5 overs (Zed Hollick 59, Blake Cattle 102, Mohit Ulva 3/37, Ishan Om 5/53) vs. India u-19 8/0 in one over; Toss: Australia.

Banton sizzles as England wraps up ODI series in style

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Tom Banton's maiden England hundred laid the foundation for a series-clinching 223-run win over Sri Lanka in the third One-Day International on Sunday.

Banton's commanding 126 was the cornerstone of England's imposing total of 355 for seven at the Oval.

Sri Lanka never looked like chasing down the target and was dismissed for 132 in the 30th over.

The scores: England 355/7 in 50 overs (Banton 126, Brook 77, Cox 76) bt Sri Lanka 132 in 29.1 overs (Dawson 3/26). Toss: England; PoM: Banton; PoS: Jacks.

Bavuma and Miller power SA to series win

Reuters
JOHANNESBURG

Temba Bavuma and David Miller both struck centuries as South Africa defeated Australia by 32 runs in a high-scoring second ODI here on Sunday to claim the three-match series with a game to spare.

South Africa amassed 365 for nine in 50 overs after being asked to bat, before bowling the visitor out for 333 in 49.5 overs as it continued its dominance with a 19th ODI win in their last 25 meetings.

Bavuma scored 103 from 116 balls for his sixth ODI century. Miller was more explosive, with nine sixes in his 142 from 93 deliveries for his career-best score and eighth ODI ton. Australia was again un-



Miller. AFP

done by spin in the middle of the innings after a fast start to its reply.

The scores: South Africa 365/9 in 50 overs (Bavuma 103, Miller 142, Edwards 5/67) bt Australia 333 in 49.5 overs (Marsh 84, Head 84, Bartlett 50). Toss: Australia; PoM: Miller.

Spain sinks England again; Modric shines

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Mikel Oyarzabal gave world champion Spain a 3-2 victory over error-prone England in the Nations League on Saturday as Luka Modric helped Croatia beat Czechia 2-1.

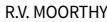
Oyarzabal struck 16 minutes from time in an entertaining contest in which England captain Harry Kane missed a penalty.

Important results:

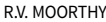
League A: Czechia 1 (Karabec 54) lost to Croatia 2 (Modric 47, Pasalic 77); England 2 (Gordon 36, Kane 40) lost to Spain 3 (Yamal 2, Baena 60, Oyarzabal 74).

League B: North Macedonia 0 lost to Switzerland 3 (Freuler 22, Amdouni 41, 74).

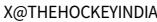
Ancy vows to come back strong after missing out on top spot



Sivasangari was incredible, I couldn't do much, says Anahat



Indian women's hockey team to play Korea in the semifinals



Kohli second after Tendulkar to score 15,000 ODI runs



Ancy misses gold by a whisker; Sarvesh brings home silver

Anahat, Abhay come up short



Firm favourites: The Men in Blue are widely tipped to retain their gold from Hangzhou. X@BCCI

Skipper Shreyas wary of challenging surface as India meets Afghanistan

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The rains in Nagoya continued for the second day and threaten to affect India's quarterfinal against Afghanistan on Monday as the men's cricket team got a feel of the ground conditions with its only training session on Sunday.

The Korogi Sports Park that also hosted the women's competition is a modified baseball field and the hybrid pitch and outfield got a positive feedback from Harmanpreet Kaur & Co. The men, coming after a one-off, five-over match against Japan in Sano, have had little time to acclimatise to Nagoya while Afghanistan has already played two matches.

The continued rain also marred the team's attempts to have a full intensity training. Captain Shreyas Iyer, however, refused to dwell on the conditions or the facilities. "Yes, it's raining but we cannot give that as a reason because we are a bunch of professionals. Such hurdles will keep coming and mentally we have to be prepared, irrespective of whatever the situation is going to be. We got a decent warm-up and a little knocking. Tomorrow, we will try to adapt as soon as possible to the wickets and see how the

weather is. The important thing is to come and play the match," Shreyas said on the eve of the match.

Afghanistan lost a three-match T20I series 0-3 in New Delhi recently but the team here is very different and inexperienced. In fact, with an almost full-strength team, India is firm favourite to retain its gold medal but Shreyas insisted on being cautious. "Not only Afghanistan, Japan gave us a very good competition. The wicket here cannot be set in a particular standard. But it is very important to adapt. It will be challenging for every team," he said.

"Today when we woke up, we thought we would be getting a little bit of practice. We knew we would be playing on turf but as soon as we arrived, the rain started again. We were able to maximise a bit in terms of our warm-up and the bowlers did some strides in the background in the outfield and sent down a couple of overs," he pointed out.

With the Games entering the business end of competition, Shreyas also hoped to catch action from other sports. "Like today, we know that an 18-year-old prodigy (Anahat Singh) is playing a squash game, so we wanted to see that. But due to practice, we couldn't go. Our support is for every individual who is representing the country," he added.

ASIAD ROUND-UP



Ankush and Parveen after their quarterfinal wins. X@MEDIA_SAI

Three Indian boxers assured of medals

NISHIO: Indian boxers Parveen Hooda, Ankush Panghal and Narender Berwal assured the country of three medals with dominant quarterfinal wins at the Asian Games here on Sunday, while Sachin Siwach's campaign ended in the last eighth stage. Parveen defeated World championships silver medallist Navbakhor Khamidova of Uzbekistan 5-0 to move into the women's 65kg semifinals. **The results (quarterfinals): Women: 65kg:** Parveen Hooda bt Navbakhor Khamidova (Uzb) 5-0. **Men: +90kg:** Narender Berwal bt Adthapong Saengtpe (Tha) RSC; **80kg:** Ankush Panghal bt Nekruz Salimov (Tjk) 5-0. **60kg:** Shunsuke Kitamoto (Jpn) bt Sachin Siwach 5-0.

Sindhu, Unnati bow out as India draws a blank

NAGOYA: P.V. Sindhu and Unnati Hooda went down in the women's singles quarterfinals on Sunday as Indian shuttlers failed to win a medal in the individual competition of

the Asian Games. Sindhu, forced to play her third match in less than 24 hours, lost to Chen Yu Fei of China 21-11, 18-21, 10-21. Unnati went down 16-21, 21-14, 17-21 to three-time World champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan. Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand suffered an 18-21, 9-21 defeat to the Malaysian World No. 5 pairing of Pearly Tan and Thinaah Muralitharan in the doubles quarterfinals. The mixed doubles duo of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto lost 14-21, 21-18, 18-21 to the Chinese World No. 1 combination of Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dongping in a last-eight clash.

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Cricket: Asian Games (Men), Afghanistan vs India, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m. & 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

The men won the silver, and the women the bronze. India, the defending champion in both the open and women's sections, could not repeat the stunning twin success of 2024, but at least finished with medals at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand.

In the open section, host Uzbekistan emerged the champion, while China came up with a dominant show to win the women's title despite not fielding some of its best players.

On the final day, the Indian men drew with Hungary 2-2, while the women shared the honours with Georgia (2-2).

The Indian men finished with 18 points, two less than the host, which defeated Ukraine 2.5-1.5. Germany, which surprised many, won the bronze after its 2.5-1.5 win over the Nether-



Impressive show: The Indian teams finished among the medals while Praggnanandhaa, Gukesh, Humpy, Divya and Savitha Shri, second right, came up with consistent displays and also took home individual prizes. FIDE

lands. Arjun Erigaisi's win over Peter Leko on the second board proved crucial, as D. Gukesh was beaten by Gleb Dudin. R. Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin drew their games.

Significant win

For the Indian women, Koneru Humpy scored a significant win on the top board against Nana Dzagnidze. Though Divya Deshmukh lost on the second board, to Bela Khotenashvili, Vantika Agrawal and

the magnificent B. Savitha Shri both drew their games to ensure India would end up on the podium, after all.

Slew of board medals

India also retained the Gaprindashvili Trophy, given to the team with the best overall score.

India is the only country to win a medal in both open and women's sections.

India also won a slew of board medals. Savitha struck gold on the reserve



board in the women's section while Divya won the silver on the second board. Humpy and Vantika the bronze on the top and fourth boards respectively. In the open section, Gukesh won the silver on the fourth board, while Praggnanandhaa claimed the bronze on the top board.

Important results (final round): Open:

India drew with Hungary 2-2 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Richard Rapport; Arjun Erigaisi bt Peter Leko; Nihal Sarin drew with



Benjamin Gledura; D. Gukesh lost to Gleb Dudin).

Uzbekistan bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; **Germany** bt Netherlands 2.5-1.5; **USA** bt Turkey 3-1; **Serbia** bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; **Armenia** bt Croatia 3-1; **China** bt Uzbekistan (2) 3-1; **France** bt Denmark 3.5-0.5; **England** bt Italy 2.5-1.5; **Spain** bt Georgia 3-1.

The standings: 1. Uzbekistan 20; 2-3. India and Germany 18; 4-7. USA, Azerbaijan, Armenia and Hungary 17; 8-10. China, France and Spain 16.

Women: India drew with Georgia 2-2 (Koneru Humpy bt Nana Dzagnidze; Divya

Deshmukh lost to Bela Khotenashvili; Vantika Agrawal drew with Lela Javakhishvili; B. Savitha Shri drew with Meri Arabadze).

Armenia bt Uzbekistan 3-1; **China** bt Vietnam 3-1; **Kazakhstan** drew with Poland 2-2; **USA** bt Romania 3-1; **Mongolia** bt Greece 2.5-1.5; **France** drew with Slovenia 2-2; **Bulgaria** drew with Latvia 2-2; **Indonesia** drew with Spain 2-2; **Turkiye** bt Sri Lanka 3-1.

The standings: 1. China 20; 2. Kazakhstan 18; 3-7. India, USA, Poland, Armenia and Mongolia 17; 8-10. Georgia, Vietnam and Slovenia 16.

Inadequate water, congestion on route mar Wipro Bengaluru Marathon

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Organisational lapses marred the 13th edition of the Wipro Bengaluru Marathon here on Sunday, with several runners complaining of inadequate water supply and poor crowd management.

Participants said water was unavailable at some stations, while congestion caused by runners from different categories affected the timings.

Organised by NEB Sports, the event attracted around 45,000 participants across four disciplines – Full Marathon, Half Marathon, 10K and 5K.

Ekta Sirohi, who ran the half-marathon, said, "After around the 10-km mark, there was no water available. All the water stations were empty."

Another participant said some well-wishers who



Flaw: An empty water station along the route. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

had gathered along the route came to the runners' aid by purchasing water bottles from nearby shops and distributing them.

There were also complaints about congestion at around the 18km mark, where runners from the Full Marathon and Half Marathon began to merge with those taking part in the 10K and 5K.

"Many of the 5K runners were walking at this stage.

On the other hand, we came in at a good speed and could not get past them," a half-marathon runner said.

NEB Sports CMD Nagaraj Adiga acknowledged the lapses and said the organisers would take the runners' feedback into account.

"In keeping with our green principles, we served water in jars and reusable cups, not bottles.

There was a delay in refilling these jars in one section of the route," Adiga told *The Hindu*.

"We are considering distributing water bottles all along the route from the next edition onwards," he said.

Adiga added that the organisers were considering holding the 10K and 5K events a day before the Full Marathon and Half Marathon in future. This, he said, would help prevent the different categories from merging on the route.

"We want to ensure that every single participant has a good experience. Our team will analyse all feedback and make the necessary improvements," Adiga said.

The results (winners):

Full marathon: Elite men: Bugatha Srinu (02:22:53). **Elite women:** Bhagirathi (03:00:18). **Half marathon: Men:** Ankit Gupta (01:09:12). **Women:** Sugandha Sharma (01:34:55).

SNAPSHOTS

Czechia beats Ukraine to win BJK Cup

SHENZHEN: Linda Noskova and Karolina Muchova delivered a first Billie Jean King Cup title since 2018 for Czechia beating Ukraine in the final on Sunday. Noskova sealed the 2-0 victory with a 6-3, 7-6(5) win over world No. 7 Elina Svitolina after Muchova put the Czechs in front with a 6-2, 6-3 win against Anhelina Kalinina.

Turlov becomes second-youngest president of FIDE

SAMARKAND: Timur Turlov was elected FIDE president at the elections

held in Samarkand on Saturday.

At 38, Turlov, who is the president of the Kazakhstan Chess Federation, is the second-youngest elected president of FIDE after Kirsan Ilyumzhinov who took office in 1995 aged 33.

Indian women to play two friendlies against Russia next month

KOLKATA: The Indian women's national team will face Russia in two international friendlies in Kolkata on October 8 and 11 during the FIFA women's international match window.

Love All primed to make it three in a row

HYDERABAD: The four-year-old filly Love All, who won in her last two starts, should score a hat-trick in the Dr. Harish Chandra Memorial Trophy, the main event of Monday's (Sept. 28) races.

1 NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200m), Terms, Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 1.15 p.m.: 1. Ashwa Vivegam (4) Gaurav 56, 2. Mantle Plume (2) B.R. Kumar 56, 3. Svalpavirysakithi (3) Md. Ismail 56, 4. Bayone (9) D.S. Deora 54.5, 5. First Kiss (10) Afroz K 54.5, 6. Lion's Pride (6) R.N. Darshan 54.5, 7. Menlo Park (8) Shivam 54.5, 8. Night Whisper (5) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 9. Veera's Lakshmi (7) Ajay K 54.5 and 10. Vespucci (0) Mohit 54.5.

1. MANTLE PLUME, 2. FIRST KISS, 3. ASHWA VIVEGAM

2 TWIN CITIES PLATE (1,800m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 46 (Cat. III), 1.45: 1. Hoping Star (7) Arjun 60, 2. Hoping High (1) Mohit 58.5, 3. Silver Arrow (5) Kuldeep Sr. 58, 4. Evansville (3) Akshay K 54, 5. Nkalanzinzi (6) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 6. Aloy (2) Sohan 53, 7. AAKARSHAKA (8) Md. Ismail 52.5 and 8. American Gangster (4) M.S. Deora 51.5.

1. EVANSVILLE, 2. HOPING HIGH, 3. HOPING STAR

3 NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200m), Terms, Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 2.15: 1. Daryoosh (1) Md. Ekram 56, 2. Sporting Touch (10) M.S. Deora 56, 3. Wildstar (6) Mukesh K 56, 4. Calista Babe (4) B. Nikhil 54.5, 5. Goddess Of Light (7) Akshay K 54.5, 6. Mazagran (3) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 7. Miss Lovely Angel (8) Ashad Asbar 54.5, 8. My Day (2) Gaurav 54.5, 9. N R I Royal Power (5) Afroz K 54.5 and 10. Sara (9) Mohit 54.5.

1. WILDSTAR, 2. GODDESS OF LIGHT, 3. MAZAGRAN

4 DR. HARISH CHANDRA MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 2.50: 1. Racing Ruler (4) Kuldeep Sr. 60, 2. Authoritarian (6) M.S. Deora 58, 3. White Pearl (1) Md. Ekram 57, 4. Special Star (3) P. Sai K 54, 5. Sangreal (5) Swarup 52.5 and 6. Love All (2) Akshay K 50.5.

1. LOVE ALL, 2. AUTHORITARIAN

5 MAJOR MIR MUJTABA HUSSAIN MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 3.25: 1. Detective (3) M.S. Deora 62, 2. Romantic Grey (10) Ashad Asbar 62, 3. Clefairy (6)

Akshay K 60.5, 4. Shadow Fax (9) Shivam 60.5, 5. Torchbearer (4) Kuldeep Jr. 60.5, 6. Clara (14) Kuldeep Sr. 58, 7. Rival (5) Ajay K 57, 8. Shoolin (1) D.S. Deora 56.5, 9. Bold Beauty (1) Md. Ismail 56, 10. Crimson Flame (7) Surya Prakash 54.5, 11. Federer (2) Arjun 54.5, 12. Petra Act (8) Mukesh K 53.5, 13. Colt Pistol (12) Sonu K 53 and 14. Coming Home (13) B. Nikhil 51.

1. CLEFAIRY, 2. RIVAL, 3. CLARA

6 NOBLE QUEST PLATE (1,200m) (Terms), 3-y-o and upward, (Cat. II) (no whips), 4.00: 1. Hurricane Bay (7) Md. Ekram 60, 2. Walking Thunder (2) Kuldeep Sr. 60, 3. N R I High Power (1) Akshay K 58.5, 4. Reigning Beauty (6) Md. Ismail 58.5, 5. Bashir (3) Abhay Singh 58, 6. Knight Regent (9) Afroz K 58, 7. D Minchu (8) Ashad Asbar 56.5, 8. Glorious Power (4) Bhavani S 56.5 and 9. Noble Heart (5) Shivam 55.

1. N R I HIGH POWER, 2. KNIGHT REGENT, 3. GLORIOUS POWER

7 NAGARKURNOOL PLATE (1,400m) Maiden, 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 4.35: 1. La Quinta (5) Akshay K 60, 2. Dream To Fly (7) G. Nareish 58.5, 3. Konaseema (9) Md. Ekram 56.5, 4. Lion's Gate (3) Arjun 55, 5. Beech Wood (10) Gaurav 54.5, 6. Farsiris (2) Sohan 54.5, 7. Divine Faith (8) B.R. Kumar 54, 8. Meadow (4) Arjun 53, 9. Sugriva (6) Mohit 53 and 10. Vedanto (10) Kuldeep Jr. 52.

1. LA QUINTA, 2. SUGRIVA, 3. BEECH WOOD

8 MAJOR MIR MUJTABA HUSSAIN MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. II) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 5.10: 1. Lucky Zone (1) Kuldeep Jr. 62, 2. Warwick (5) Ashad Asbar 62, 3. Dyanooosh (1) Sonu 60.5, 4. Best Buddy (9) R.S. Jodha 59.5, 5. Arthisha (4) Mukesh K 58, 6. Lazarus (7) R.N. Darshan 57.5, 7. Vital Sign (8) B.R. Kumar 57, 8. Basilica (12) Akshay K 56, 9. Catchme If You Can (6) B. Nikhil 54, 10. Mix The Magic (13) D.S. Deora 54, 11. Blue Pantheress (10) Rafique Sk. 53.5, 12. Hurricane Wave (3) Md. Ekram 53 and 13. Jura-mento (2) Uday Kiran 50.

1. ARTHISHA, 2. BASILICA, 3. HURRICANE WAVE

Day's Best: LOVE ALL
Jackpot: 4, 5, 6, 7 & 8. Mini Jackpot: 6, 2, 3, 4 & 5, (ii) 5, 6, 7 & 8. Treble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 3, 4 & 5, (iii) 6, 7 & 8. Tanala: All races.

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

There was a moment in the second half of the Asian Games kabaddi gold-medal match against Iran when Aslam Inamdar made a daring raid deep into the opposition half.

His teammate Pawan Sehrawat groaned inwardly as he did so. India's lead was narrow. Iran was still in the contest. It was a risk that could have gone badly wrong. "It was a bad decision," Pawan would say later. But Inamdar made the dash count, securing two touches and emerging unscathed. The points brought India closer to victory. "It was a wrong move, but *ant bhala toh sab bhala* (if the end is good, it's all worth it)," Inamdar said after the match.

He grinned when he recalled the sequence later. It had been a tough decision to make. Wasn't he worried when he made that move? What would have happened if it had gone wrong? "*Bhai*, I've gone through things you wouldn't even imagine. This is nothing," he said.

That, in many ways, is the story of Aslam Inamdar.

There was a time when, as a 14-year-old, he travelled across Maharashtra in search of kabaddi tournaments without even having enough money for a train ticket. He slept under train seats, survived on stale vada pav or whatever food was available at tournaments. He sometimes stuffed leftover food which often spilled into his bag. "If there was work to be done, I did it. I've cleaned toilets. I've sold juice and made tea. I've worked in fields. If there was a kabaddi tournament to play, I found a way to get there."

In Nagoya on Saturday, Inamdar stood on the mat as India beat Iran to win the men's kabaddi gold. It is his second Asian Games gold medal. The distance between those two versions of Inamdar is difficult even for him to comprehend.

"It still feels like a dream to me," he said. "I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals."

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children.

His father passed away when he was young, leaving his mother to raise the family. She worked in other homes, doing household chores and washing utensils, to keep the family going. Later, his elder brother Waseem joined the police force and took responsibility, including helping arrange the marriages of their two sisters.

Money was scarce. Inamdar remembers growing up in a house without proper flooring or roof. There were times when even food was difficult to come by.

So, he learnt early that work meant survival. At 11 or 12, he collected



discarded bottles and sold them to scrap dealers to buy food. Later, he worked at tea stalls and juice bars, washed utensils, cleaned washrooms and worked in farm fields. He admits he stole sometimes. "It was just to fill my stomach. I faced many hard situations without letting them break me," he said.

Through all of it, there was one constant: kabaddi. Waseem was a well-known player across several districts while senior player Rahul Bhor also inspired him. Inamdar wanted to establish his own identity. "No matter how long I worked during the day or night, I always went to the ground to train," the raider said.

Kabaddi was a sport he could afford. It required little equipment, and the village ground was enough. For a boy with very little money, it offered something priceless: a chance. By the time he was 14 or 15, Inamdar was travelling alone to tournaments to compete in the 50kg and 55kg categories. He earned between ₹200

From cleaning rest rooms to winning two Asian Games golds – the rise of Aslam Inamdar

The star raider has cleared many hurdles and come a long way since taking to kabaddi when he was about 14; irrespective of the hardships, the sport has been a constant



and ₹500 a match. The money was little, but it mattered. It bought him meals when he might otherwise have gone hungry. More importantly, it kept him moving from one tournament to the next. The path was neither smooth nor uninterrupted. In 2014, while India competed at the Asian Games, Inamdar was at

home nursing a fractured leg and following kabaddi on television. His life at the time seemed a world away from an international career. "I was just watching kabaddi on TV. But I believe God's plans are always better. My hard work never stopped."

He kept working. Eventually, the Pro Kabaddi League changed the scale of his life.

In his first season, he earned ₹8 lakh. For someone who had once struggled to put food on the table, the money was almost incomprehensible. "Eight lakh felt like eight crore to me," he said.

He did not forget where he had come from. With his first major earnings, he bought a gold necklace for his mother. Kabaddi had given him something that had once seemed almost impossible: financial security, recognition and a career. He went on to captain Puneri Paltan and establish himself as one of India's leading players. Then came the international medals.

Inamdar won his first Asian Games gold in Hangzhou. Three years later in Nagoya, he has another. And once again, the final was against Iran – the one opponent which has consistently pushed India hardest at the Asian Games. "Iran is generally the most challenging opponent for us," Inamdar said. "It has a strong defence and has very experienced players like Fazel Atrachali, who played in his fifth Asian Games."

For Inamdar, beating such a formidable opponent made the gold more meaningful. "A tough challenge makes winning the gold medal feel even more rewarding."

But for Inamdar, the significance of the medal lies beyond the result. It is the culmination of a journey that began when he was a boy travelling across Maharashtra for a few hundred rupees, when he collected scrap bottles for food and worked whatever jobs he could find before heading to the kabaddi ground.

Today, he tries to pass on that experience to younger players. At his training ground in Thane, he speaks to juniors, particularly those from underprivileged backgrounds, about his own journey. He wants them to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up. "I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have. I want them to know that whatever happens, they shouldn't stop working hard. They shouldn't stop believing," he said.



It still feels like a dream to me. I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals



Iran is generally the most challenging opponent. It has a strong defence and has experienced players like Fazel Atrachali

THE GIST

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children

He clinched both his gold medals after defeating Iran in finals

The raider wants the next generation to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up

COP31 hosts Australia and Türkiye face the fossil-fuel question

There is likely to be pressure on the COP31 presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26 and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31

Rishika Pardikar
TRABZON, TÜRKİYE

The next United Nations climate change conference, COP31, will be held in Antalya in Türkiye in November this year. Türkiye will be hosting the event, with its Minister of Environment Murat Kurum serving as COP31 President. Australia will oversee the negotiations process, with its Minister for Climate Change and Energy Chris Bowen as the Vice-President of COP31.

This is a novel arrangement – a result of both Australia and Türkiye not being willing to concede their demand to host, and where both countries share crucial responsibilities. In previous editions, the COP’s physical host has differed from the President only for logistical reasons.

A pre-COP event will be held in Fiji on October 5-8, where Pacific Island countries and Australia will discuss preparations for the main event, including what to negotiate. These pre-COPs are a routine affair before the annual summits.

Domestic fossil reliance

Both Türkiye and Australia are heavy users of fossil fuels. Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter, after Russia and the U.S. Domestically, Australia as well as Türkiye rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their energy needs. Three weeks ago, Australia also came under fire from climate groups for approving the expansion of a coal mine.

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn “to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035”.

‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda: Türkiye hosted a ‘Blue Dialogue’ on September 10-11 whose focus was on protecting marine resources.

However, none of the themes listed as a priority for the event make direct reference to transitioning away from fossil fuels.

That said, various industries in Australia, including iron-ore mining, are trying to decarbonise by investing in hybrid or electric heavy machinery. Local governments are also pushing for electric vehicles (EVs), which recently overtook petrol car sales for the first time in Australia.

Türkiye, on the other hand, is working to augment recycling and so eventually reduce methane emissions. In fact, the country has listed ‘zero waste and a circular economy’ on the COP31 priority list. The fortunes of a local EV brand,



An oil rig is visible in the distance near Cape Town harbour. ALPHA PERSPECTIVE/UNSPASH

Togg, has ballooned so much that the government hopes it will herald a new era in the automobiles market.

Loss and damage financing

At the COP30 in Belém, Brazil, last year, the European Union pushed for a “fossil fuel roadmap” to help countries worldwide transition away from fossil fuels. While many countries supported the call, observers have said it took the focus away from developing countries’ calls to triple adaptation finance and developed countries’ resistance to that.

That said, most countries involved in the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) did not oppose the call for the “fossil fuel road map” at COP30.

India did not oppose either, on the condition that it incorporate the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and that countries are not expected to follow uniform energy transition pathways. Beyond the UNFCCC framework as well, and partly because of the slow pace of negotiations at the COP summits, there have been calls for concrete action to transition away from fossil fuels. In April this year, the first conference on “Transitioning Away from Fossil Fuels” was held in Santa Marta in Colombia, co-hosted by Colombia and the Netherlands.

The second conference is scheduled

for 2027, to be co-hosted by Tuvalu and Ireland.

Given such momentum, there is likely to be pressure on the COP31 Presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26, boosted no doubt by climate change, and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31, and to loss and damage financing. But as with their not mentioning the transition away from fossil fuels, the joint Australia-Türkiye presidents have also included no loss and damage financing, or even the broader climate finance question, among the priority topics.

“We know there are strong views on all sides of this topic,” the Türkiye Presidency said in response to questions from the author about whether this will change. “We will create space for Parties to discuss the transition and listen carefully to the positions they bring forward to see what we can agree by consensus. But listening to Parties’ views on negotiations does not mean we are standing still. We are taking the next logical steps in the energy transition by making electrification the flagship thematic priority of the COP31 Presidency’s Action Agenda, because electrifying buildings, transport and industry is key to reducing emissions and

should be accompanied by complementary efforts to expand renewable energy.

Likewise, the reply said on mitigation financing: “we have been clear that we need to close the climate finance chasm, and we are holding donors to the financial commitments made at past COPs, while also introducing innovative new mechanisms, such as the ‘Climate Implementation Bridge’, to address the gap between ambitious climate plans and the finance needed to make them a reality.”

The Australian Presidency did not respond.

Countries participating at COPs can propose new agenda items for consideration during negotiations. For example, the European Union introduced the “road map” in the formal negotiations agenda at the last minute at COP30. That said, it remains to be seen whether countries will do so at COP31, and if so what the items will be – and ultimately how the event’s two fossil fuel-heavy stewards will navigate negotiations.

The author was in Türkiye September 8-13 at the invitation of the government for a COP31-themed media tour. She also visited Australia in October 2025 on a similar official tour.

(Rishika Pardikar is a freelance journalist. rishika.s.pardikar@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Australia and Türkiye are heavy users of fossil fuels; both countries rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their domestic energy needs; Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn ‘to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035’; ‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda

At COP30, the EU advocated a global ‘fossil fuel roadmap’ to guide the transition away from fossil fuels; critics said it diverted attention from developing nations’ demand for tripling adaptation finance

BIG SHOT



Coastal fury: Waves caused by Hurricane Polo seen battering a small island with houses off the coast of San Blas in Mexico on September 26; It moved away from Mexico's Pacific coast on Saturday as a Category 4 storm and is expected to return to make landfall in Baja California Sur on Monday, forecasters said. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

UN Sea Level Declaration

Vasudevan Mukunth

On September 24, the United Nations General Assembly approved the Declaration on Sea Level Rise by consensus.

Perhaps its most important provision concerns international law. The Declaration affirms that low-lying countries especially threatened by rising seas, such as Fiji, Tuvalu, and Vanuatu, will continue to retain their statehood, sovereign rights, and UN membership. It also says maritime zones will continue to be defined in line with the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea, even if rising waters cause coastlines to retreat further inland.

The Declaration arose from a high-level meeting in 2024 and which member countries had since negotiated under a mandate calling for an action-oriented agreement. Spanning four pages, the Declaration organises action around (i) science and data, (ii) adaptation and financing, (iii) livelihoods, socio-economic development, data-sharing, and early-warnings, and (iv) the legal consequences of sea-level rise.

It also calls on countries to respond to sea-level rise in a way that addresses livelihoods and cultural heritage and with the involvement of affected communities.

The world’s low-lying island states — which have organised themselves as the Alliance of Small Island States in international fora, including the COP



The current global mean sea-level rise is 4-5 mm/year. LOOK UP LOOK DOWN PHOTOGRAPHY/UNSPASH

climate talks — need these assurances because the seas surrounding them threaten to swallow most or all of their habitable territory in the coming decades. If they do, the Declaration will ensure their citizens continue to retain their nationality and economic rights.

The pact also commits UN member countries to continue to engage on issues related to sea-level rise, including a high-level meeting before the 84th session of the General Assembly ends.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people rescued during floods in Chhattisgarh

5,000 Nearly 5,000 people were rescued in the last two days after heavy rains swelled rivers in Chhattisgarh, officials said on Sunday. The administration has set up 43 relief camps in urban and rural areas of the Bastar district. The Indravati river level rose to 12.56 metres by 8 p.m. on Saturday, 4.26 metres above the danger mark. PTI

People who died in separate mass shootings in S. Africa

27 The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg. The second happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town. No arrests had been made in the two shootings, which came just five days after another mass shooting near the city of Durban killed at least 11 people. Shootings are the most common form of homicide in South Africa. PTI

Palestinians killed by Israel in Gaza since October 2023

74,016 While a ceasefire that took effect on October 10 last year has halted the heaviest fighting, Israeli strikes have continued in what the military described as responses to threats or attacks. Since the ceasefire, 1,145 Palestinians have been killed, said the Ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led government. PTI

Missing trainee teachers honoured by protesters in Mexico

43 Thousands of protesters wore red and carried symbolic coffins at a demonstration in Mexico City on Saturday, demanding answers about the 43 trainee teachers who went missing 12 years ago. Prosecutors initially said officers delivered the teacher trainees to drug cartel hitmen, who killed them. Independent human rights experts have rejected the conclusion. AFP

People rescued from child trafficking racket in Arunachal Pradesh

51 According to Namsai Superintendent of Police Sange Thinley, sustained investigation and coordinated operations led to a significant jump in rescued children from 19 during the initial phase to 51, including four adults. During the initial crackdown, the police rescued 19 children, most of them below eight years of age. PTI

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Should voting be a fundamental right?

A recent *Indian Express* report revealed an unprecedented rift within the EC over alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, prompting a re-examination of the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one

LETTER & SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh

On September 23, an *Indian Express* investigation revealed an unprecedented rift within the three-member Election Commission of India (EC), with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recording 14 objections over 10 months against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, regarding alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, without the Commission’s full approval.

The report also found that 97 eligible voters from Goa were excluded from the electoral roll after the centralised ECINet software prevented ground-level Electoral Registration Officers (ERO) from reversing decisions. More concerning, the consequences extend beyond the loss of voting rights. Reportedly, several State schemes use electoral rolls to establish eligibility, including the Goa Mediclaim Scheme. The scheme covers super-speciality treatments unavailable in government hospitals, such as dialysis, angioplasty, open-heart surgery, transplants, chemotherapy and cochlear implants, and is available only to State voters. This issue has once again cast a spotlight on the ‘right to vote’, the foundational processes of India’s electoral machinery, and the genesis of India’s ‘universal adult suffrage’ (UAS).

What shaped adult suffrage in India? India’s constitutional promise of the ‘right to vote’ differs significantly from that of many Western democracies. Reflecting the flawed belief, espoused by thinkers like J.S. Mill, that voting should be reserved for the “enlightened”, countries like the U.K. initially restricted the franchise to male property owners. Universal male suffrage emerged only in 1918, and women were granted the ‘right to vote’ a decade later in 1928. In the U.S., although the 15th and 19th Amendments extended voting rights to African Americans (1870) and women (1920), systemic barriers such as poll taxes and literacy tests continued to disenfranchise many for decades thereafter.

In sharp contrast, India’s choice of immediate, universal inclusion ensured ‘democratic equality’ from the outset, bypassing the prolonged and often violent struggles seen elsewhere. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’, regardless of gender, caste, religion, education, or property. This commitment to a robust, inclusive democracy found further constitutional reinforcement in a series of Supreme Court judgments, notably starting with *Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala* (1973), which established democracy as part of the ‘basic structure’ doctrine. For this ideal to function meaningfully, people should be able to freely decide the fate of their government.

This inclusive vision was operationalised through two key laws: the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which governs the preparation and revision of electoral rolls; and the 1951 Act, which regulates election conduct, candidature, and electoral offences. The EC has repeatedly introduced administrative innovations to realise this ‘constitutional promise’.

Notably, the then Chief Election Commissioner Sukumar Sen, faced with the task of enrolling 173 million largely illiterate voters, turned a logistical hurdle into a democratic breakthrough by



Enabling democracy: Courts have regarded the right to vote as an inseparable part of democracy, as it enables citizens to shape governance. R. ASHOK

introducing election symbols, making UAS practically accessible.

In India, the EC has the responsibility to reach the last citizen, wherever they may be, to actualise their ‘right to elect’.

What is the legal status of right to vote?

The legal status of the ‘right to vote’ in India has long been debated, and whether it is classified as a statutory, constitutional, or fundamental right determines how easily it can be changed, how it is enforced, and the level of legal protection it receives. Although Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and K.T. Shah proposed including it in the Constitution’s fundamental rights part, the Constituent Assembly’s Advisory Committee ultimately rejected the idea. Importantly, a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in *Kuldip Nayar v. Union of India* (2006) held that the ‘right to elect’ is a statutory right under Section 62 of the RPA, 1951, and not a fundamental or constitutional right.

Though a two-judge Bench in *Rajbala v. State of Haryana* described the ‘right to vote’ as a constitutional right in 2015, the larger bench ruling in *Kuldip Nayar* prevails. Again, in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* (2023), the top court declined to pronounce on the issue, noting that it had already been settled by the five-judge Bench in the *Kuldip Nayar* judgment. However, in his dissent, Justice Ajay Rastogi asserted that the ‘right to vote’ is an expression of Article 19(1)(a) and reflects the essence of Article 21. Yet, as this view remains a minority opinion, the ‘right to elect’ continues to be recognised as a statutory right.

Nevertheless, even though it is not a fundamental right, courts have regarded the ‘right to vote’ as an inseparable part of democracy, anchoring their reasoning in the idea that it enables citizens to shape governance, making it a “democratic imperative” vital to the Indian republic’s survival.

Why do we need accurate poll rolls?

Free and fair elections rest on accurate electoral rolls under the RPA, 1950. Inaccuracies – such as mass omissions, ineligible inclusions, duplicates, or incorrect entries – undermine the “one person, one vote” principle by enabling impersonation, disenfranchisement, or

dilution of votes, ultimately distorting the people’s mandate. Therefore, the EC is empowered under Section 21 of the 1950 Act to prepare and revise these rolls to ensure integrity. The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 lays down how the EC must transact its business. Section 17 requires the Commission’s business to be conducted in accordance with the Act, while Section 18 provides that its procedure and allocation of business may be regulated by unanimous decision. It further requires business to be transacted as far as possible unanimously, but where the CEC and other Commissioners differ, the matter is decided by majority.

Deriving its authority from Article 324, the EC serves as the constitutional guardian of elections, with powers of superintendence, direction, and control. A key duty is preparing accurate electoral rolls, guided by Section 19 of the RPA, 1950, which mandates that any citizen aged 18 or above, “ordinarily resident” in a constituency and not disqualified, is entitled to be registered. “Ordinary resident” implies a genuine, continuous presence, not a temporary stay.

While discrepancies may arise, courts have consistently held that only substantial and systemic errors that demonstrably “materially affected” the election outcome can compromise the sanctity of the electoral roll. Minor mistakes or isolated disenfranchisement are insufficient.

Yet the recent Goa episode complicates this comfortable “substantial versus isolated” binary that courts have relied on. The *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters were dropped from the rolls, not through electoral fraud but because the ECINet software architecture itself denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. What makes the episode damning is not merely the exclusion, but the apparent unresponsiveness that followed. The EROs reportedly flagged the anomalies to the Commission by email, yet the corrections were not restored. This is not the isolated clerical error that courts have historically forgiven; it is a systemic failure baked into the software’s design, compounded by administrative inertia.

While the right to inclusion or

objection in electoral rolls is conferred on individuals, not political parties, the court in *Lakshmi Charan Sen v. A.K.M. Hassan Uzzaman* (1985) observed that in a largely illiterate and politically unaware electorate, parties should take steps to ensure eligible voters are included, and ineligible ones are removed. Given India’s party-based Parliamentary system, such vigilance will help in preserving ‘electoral integrity’.

What lies ahead?

The revelations against the EC lend fresh urgency to the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one. If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the franchise can itself be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will, is precarious.

Many scholars argue that the ‘right to vote’ cannot be regarded as merely a statutory right, as it flows from Article 326, and any legislation regulating it must conform to the parameters prescribed by Articles 325 and 326. It is therefore necessary to ensure that the legislature does not impose irrational or unreasonable restrictions on the ‘right to vote’, particularly since “free and fair elections” and “democracy” are basic features of the Constitution.

Justice Rastogi’s dissent in *Anoop Baranwal*, over the legal status of the ‘right to vote’, offers doctrinal ground for a larger Bench to revisit the question that the majority in *Kuldip Nayar* considered settled.

Elevating the ‘right to vote’ to fundamental status would not diminish the EC’s authority to purify rolls; it would instead subject that authority to the heightened standard of judicial review reserved for fundamental rights, ensuring that the drive to centralise electoral administration is always weighed against, rather than allowed to override, the citizen’s claim to be counted. In a democracy where software now mediates the relationship between the voter and the ballot, the constitutional status of the ‘right to vote’ can no longer remain a matter of legislative grace. (*Kartikey Singh is a lawyer based in New Delhi.*)

THE GIST

India’s choice of immediate, universal adult suffrage ensured democratic equality from the outset. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’

An *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters from Goa were dropped from the rolls because the ECINet software denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. This is not an isolated clerical error, but a systemic failure, compounded by administrative inertia

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